StashingFintech

Cloud Security Report

Identity, network, container, storage and monitoring controls in Microsoft Azure

CyBlack Internship, September 2026 cohort

Sprint 2: Cloud Security

Team 2

Prepared by

Philip Chukwukere
Utibe Anthony Akpan
Chongmin Edet
Opeyemi Olatunji
Onifade Damilare
Ekundayo Gabriel Olumide
Chizzym Marcus
Summaiyya Aliyu

Contents

Executive summary **4**

Scope, method and platform **6**

The organisation 6

The platform 6

How we worked 6

Anonymisation 6

Limits 6

1. Role-based access control **7**

1.1 Objective 7

1.2 Configuration 7

1.3 Verification 9

1.4 Issues and resolutions 10

1.5 Conclusion 10

2. Network security groups and application security groups **11**

2.1 Objective 11

2.2 Configuration 11

2.3 Tests and results 12

2.4 Issues and resolutions 13

2.5 Conclusion 14

3. Azure Firewall **15**

3.1 Objective 15

3.2 Configuration 15

3.3 Tests and results 16

3.4 Issues and resolutions 17

3.5 Conclusion 17

4. Azure Container Registry and Azure Kubernetes Service **18**

4.1 Objective 18

4.2 Configuration 18

4.3 Tests and results 19

4.4 Issues and resolutions 21

4.5 Conclusion 21

5. Service endpoints and securing storage **22**

5.1 Objective 22

5.2 Configuration 22

5.3 Tests and results 23

5.4 Issues and resolutions 25

5.5 Conclusion 25

6. Log Analytics workspace, storage account and data collection rule **26**

6.1 Objective 26

6.2 Configuration 26

6.3 Verification 28

6.4 Issues and resolutions 28

6.5 Conclusion 28

7. Microsoft Defender for Cloud enhanced security for servers **29**

7.1 Objective 29

7.2 Configuration 29

7.3 Verification 29

7.4 Issues and resolutions 29

7.5 Conclusion 29

8. Just-in-time virtual machine access **30**

8.1 Objective..... 30
8.2 Configuration..... 30
8.3 Tests and results..... 30
8.4 Issues and resolutions..... 31
8.5 Conclusion..... 31
9. Microsoft Sentinel for SIEM and SOAR..... 32
9.1 Objective..... 32
9.2 Configuration..... 32
9.3 Tests and results..... 35
9.4 Issues and resolutions..... 35
9.5 Conclusion..... 36
10. Conclusions and recommendations for StashingFintech..... 37
References..... 39
Appendix A: Evidence index..... 40

Executive summary

Purpose and approach

This report presents the nine hands-on Microsoft Azure security labs that Team 2 completed in Sprint 2 of the CyBlack Internship, acting as the cloud security team of StashingFintech, a Lagos-based payments fintech. The labs follow the structure of Microsoft's AZ-500 lab set and cover the main layers of cloud security: identity and access control (Lab 1), network filtering (Labs 2 and 3), container workloads (Lab 4), storage hardening (Lab 5), logging and monitoring (Lab 6), threat protection and access control on virtual machines (Labs 7 and 8), and security monitoring with automated response (Lab 9). Each section states the objective, the configuration built, the tests run and their results, the issues met and how they were resolved, and a conclusion for StashingFintech.

Identity and access

Lab 1 created three users and three groups through the Azure portal, PowerShell and the Azure CLI, and assigned the Virtual Machine Contributor role to a group at resource group scope rather than to a person. A direct assignment to an individual user left over from an earlier attempt was found during verification and removed, so that access now depends only on group membership.

Network security

Lab 2 showed that one network security group on a subnet can treat two servers differently on the basis of their application security group alone: the management server accepted remote desktop connections and the web server refused them, while the web server served HTTP. Lab 3 routed a workload subnet through Azure Firewall, which allowed www.bing.com and blocked www.microsoft.com with its default deny action.

Container workloads

Lab 4 built a private container registry and an Azure Kubernetes Service cluster that pulled an nginx image from that registry through a managed identity with no stored credential. The same image was published once on a public load balancer and once on an internal load balancer, and only the public one was reachable from outside the virtual network.

Storage

Lab 5 combined a service endpoint and a storage firewall with a network security group. The private subnet could map the file share but not reach the internet, and the public subnet could reach the internet but was refused by the storage account. The tests showed that the two controls act independently.

Monitoring and response

Labs 6 to 9 built the monitoring layer: a data collection rule feeding a Log Analytics workspace, Microsoft Defender for Servers, just-in-time virtual machine access, and a Microsoft Sentinel detection that raised incidents and triggered a playbook when the just-in-time policy was removed. The playbook ran on each incident but its incident lookup step returned NotFound, so the automated severity change did not complete.

Recurring issues

Three problems recurred. Free-trial subscriptions blocked several virtual machine and node sizes and did not permit Azure Container Registry Tasks (Labs 2, 3 and 4). Lab files were missing or out of date (Labs 3 and 4). Configuration errors, such as a wrong port or a rule saved with the wrong action, were found by testing rather than by reading the settings (Labs 2, 4 and 5). Each is described in the Issues and resolutions subsection of its lab.

Recommendations

Section 10 presents eleven prioritised recommendations with owners. The most urgent are to keep management ports closed by default behind just-in-time access or Azure Bastion, to grant Azure roles to groups and review direct assignments, to require a second person to confirm every firewall rule before it is saved, to

> use identity-based access instead of storage account keys, and to tune Sentinel analytics rules for log ingestion delay.

Scope, method and platform

The organisation

StashingFintech is a payments company that provides payment infrastructure and APIs to businesses across Africa, with headquarters in Lagos, Nigeria. The labs treat the Azure environment as the company's cloud estate and judge each control by what it would mean for a payments business.

The platform

The team worked in two Azure free-trial subscriptions, one per sub-team, each in its own Microsoft Entra tenant. Every team member received a member account in the tenant and the Owner role on the subscription, because several labs create role assignments. Work was done in the Azure portal and in Azure Cloud Shell (Bash and PowerShell). Resources were deployed to East US unless the subscription refused a size in that region.

How we worked

The eight team members split into two sub-teams of four. Team A covered identity and monitoring (Labs 1, 6, 7, 8 and 9) and Team B covered network and workload security (Labs 2, 3, 4 and 5). In each lab one person drove the portal and shared the screen while a second person followed the lab text, checked each setting and captured the evidence. Every lab's resource group was deleted when the lab ended, so the screenshots in this report are the only record of the configurations. Appendix A lists every figure and its source.

Anonymisation

StashingFintech is the working name used for the organisation throughout this report. The organisation's real name does not appear in the text, the figures or the references. Resource names that include the working name, such as the storage account in Lab 6, were created by the team.

Limits

Free-trial subscriptions are limited to 4 vCPUs per region, cannot use many virtual machine sizes in busy regions and do not permit Azure Container Registry Tasks. The lab document is older than the current platform: it refers to a retired PowerShell module, to lab files that no longer exist in Microsoft's repository and to a hard-coded line number that does not match a hand-typed file. Where a screenshot was taken before a configuration error was corrected, the caption says so. The automated response in Lab 9 did not complete, and the reason is recorded in that section.

1. Role-based access control

1.1 Objective

The objective was to create users and groups with three different administrative tools and to grant access through a group rather than to an individual. Three users were required: Joseph Price, created in the Azure portal and placed in a Senior Admins group; Isabel Garcia, created with PowerShell and placed in a Junior Admins group; and Dylan Williams, created with the Azure CLI and placed in a Service Desk group. The Service Desk group then received the Virtual Machine Contributor role on the resource group AZ500Lab01, and the effective access of Dylan Williams and Joseph Price was checked.

1.2 Configuration

Table 1.1 lists the identities, the tool used to create each one and the access that resulted. The resource group AZ500Lab01 was created in East US. The role was assigned to the group with the resource group as its scope, so the permission applies to that resource group only.

Table 1.1: Users, groups and role assignments created in Lab 1

User	Created with	Group	Access
Joseph Price	Azure portal	Senior Admins (owner and member)	No role assignment on AZ500Lab01
Isabel Garcia	PowerShell in Cloud Shell	Junior Admins	No role assignment on AZ500Lab01
Dylan Williams	Azure CLI (Bash) in Cloud Shell	Service Desk	Virtual Machine Contributor on AZ500Lab01, inherited from the Service Desk group

```
chongmin [ ~ ]$ az ad user list --output table
DisplayName     GivenName    PreferredLanguage    Surname    UserPrincipalName
--------------  -----------  -------------------  ---------  ------------------------------------
--------------------------
Utibe Akpan     Utibe        en                   Akpan      akpanutibe342_gmail.com#EXT#@akpanu
tibe342gmail.onmicrosoft.com
Chongmin                                                     Chongmin@akpanutibe342gmail.onmicro
soft.com
Dami                                                         Dami@akpanutibe342gmail.onmicrosoft
.com
Dylan Williams                                               Dylan@akpanutibe342gmail.onmicrosof
t.com
Isabel Garcia                                                Isabel@akpanutibe342gmail.onmicroso
ft.com
Joseph Price                                                 Joseph-Price@akpanutibe342gmail.onm
icrosoft.com
Summaiyya                                                    Summaiyya@akpanutibe342gmail.onmicr
osoft.com
chongmin [ ~ ]$
```

Figure 1.1: Output of az ad user list in Cloud Shell. The three lab users, Dylan Williams, Isabel Garcia and Joseph Price, appear in the tenant alongside the team accounts.

```
chongmin [ ~ ]$ az ad group member add --group "Service Desk" --member-id $OBJECTID
chongmin [ ~ ]$ az ad group member list --group "Service Desk"
[
  {
    "@odata.type": "#microsoft.graph.user",
    "businessPhones": [],
    "displayName": "Dylan Williams",
    "givenName": null,
    "id": "87329cb3-2dbd-430f-908f-ee24a14b0b53",
    "jobTitle": null,
    "mail": null,
    "mobilePhone": null,
    "officeLocation": null,
    "preferredLanguage": null,
    "surname": null,
    "userPrincipalName": "Dylan@akpanutibe342gmail.onmicrosoft.com"
  }
]
chongmin [ ~ ]$
```

Figure 1.2: Dylan Williams added to the Service Desk group with az ad group member add. The group member list confirms the membership.

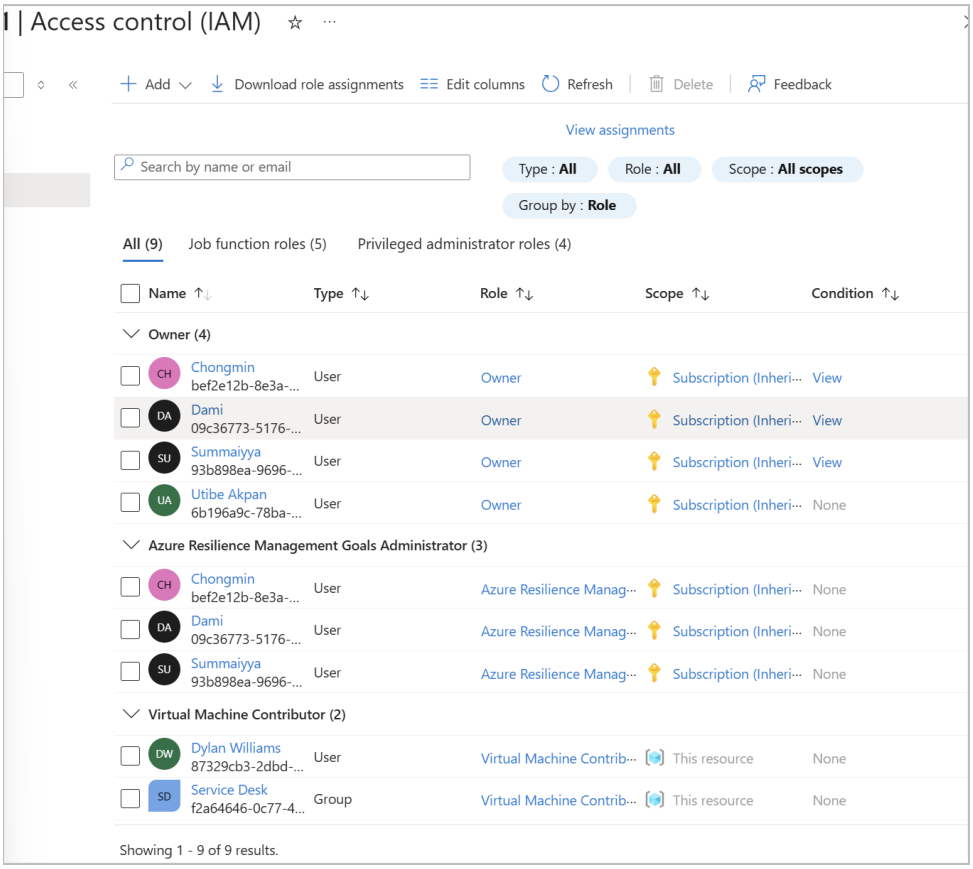


Figure 1.3: Access control (IAM) for AZ500Lab01 before cleanup. Virtual Machine Contributor is held by the Service Desk group and, from an earlier attempt, by Dylan Williams directly. The direct assignment was removed.

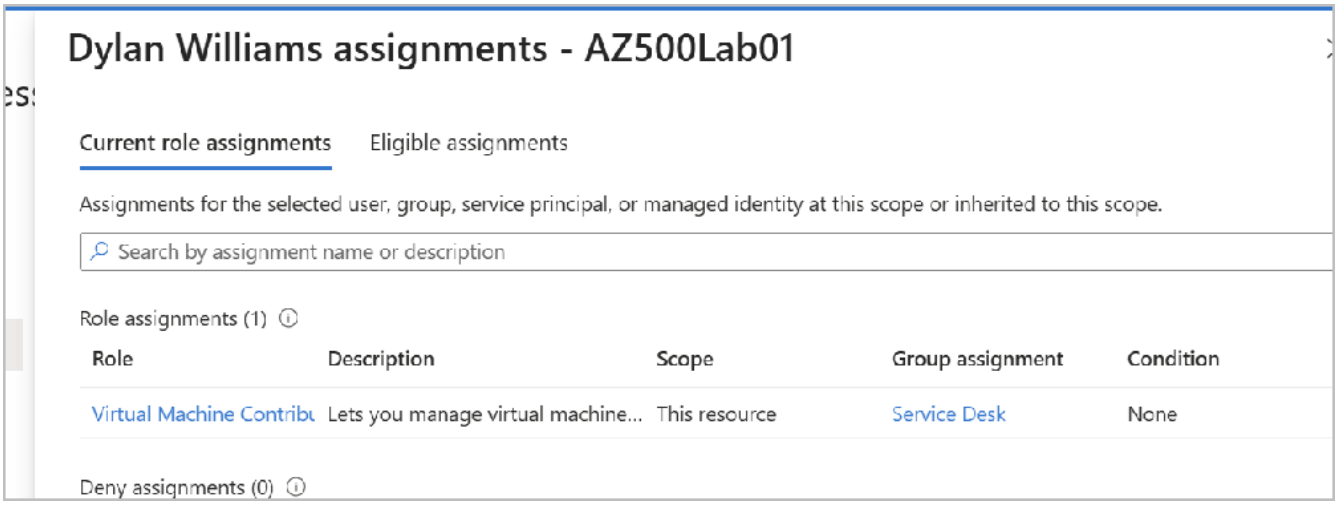


Figure 1.4: Role assignments for Dylan Williams on AZ500Lab01 after cleanup. One assignment, Virtual Machine Contributor at this resource, with the Group assignment column showing Service Desk.

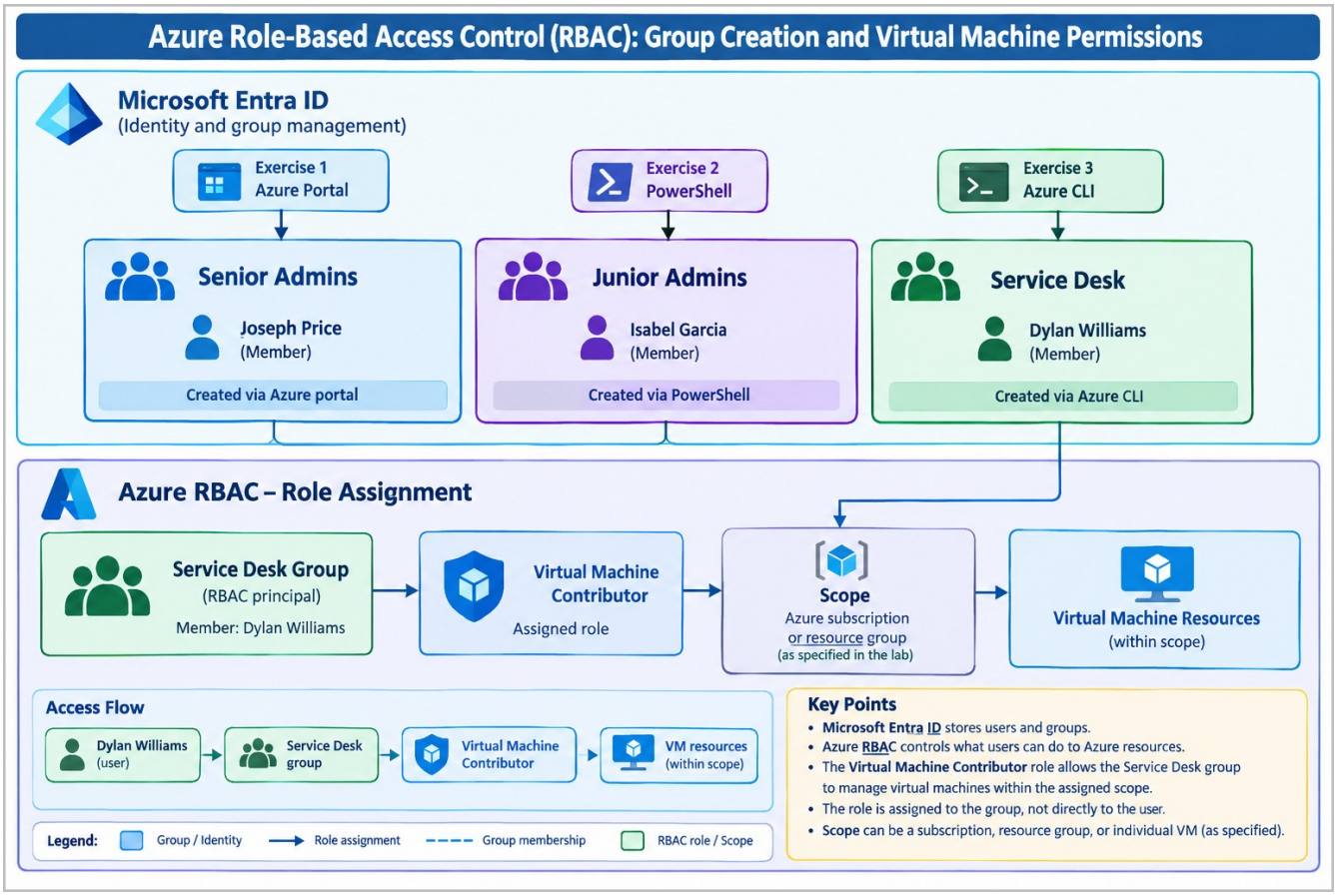


Figure 1.5: Summary of the Lab 1 design. Three users created with three tools, three groups, and one role assignment granted to the Service Desk group at resource group scope.

1.3 Verification

Three checks confirmed the result (Table 1.2). All six objects exist in the tenant, Dylan Williams holds Virtual Machine Contributor on AZ500Lab01 only through his group membership, and Joseph Price holds no role on the resource group because the Senior Admins group was never given one.

Table 1.2: Verification checks for Lab 1

Check	Expected result	Observed result
Users and groups exist in the tenant	Three users and three groups	Confirmed in the portal and in az ad user list and az ad group list (Figures 1.1 and 1.2)
Access of Dylan Williams on AZ500Lab01	Virtual Machine Contributor through Service Desk	Confirmed. Group assignment column shows Service Desk (Figure 1.4)
Access of Joseph Price on AZ500Lab01	No role assignment	Confirmed. No assignment at resource group scope

1.4 Issues and resolutions

Two commands in the Azure CLI exercise failed as written. The command that retrieves the tenant domain name used quoting that the shell rejected, and was replaced with az ad signed-in-user show --query userPrincipalName -o tsv piped through cut. The command that retrieves the object ID of the new user piped the shell variable $USER into jq, which failed because $USER holds the local Linux user name rather than JSON. It was replaced with az ad user show --id Dylan@$DOMAINNAME --query id -o tsv. During verification the Virtual Machine Contributor role was found assigned both to the Service Desk group and directly to Dylan Williams, left over from an earlier attempt. The direct assignment was removed so that access depends on group membership alone.

1.5 Conclusion

The lab showed the same identity objects being created from the portal, PowerShell and the CLI, and the value of assigning roles to groups at a narrow scope. Dylan Williams' access to AZ500Lab01 ends automatically when he leaves the Service Desk group, and the role reaches no other resource group. The direct assignment found during verification shows why role assignments need periodic review, since a grant to a person bypasses the group model without any warning.

2. Network security groups and application security groups

2.1 Objective

The objective was to control traffic to two virtual machines by role rather than by IP address. Two application security groups (ASGs) act as labels, one for web servers and one for management servers. A single network security group (NSG) on the subnet carries two rules written against those labels, and the tests confirm that each server accepts only the traffic intended for its role.

2.2 Configuration

The resource group AZ500LAB07 holds a virtual network with one subnet, two ASGs, one NSG attached to the subnet and two Windows Server 2022 virtual machines. Both machines were created with public inbound ports set to None and no NSG on the network interface, so the subnet NSG is the only filter in the path. Each network interface was then joined to its ASG. Until that step is done the rules match nothing, because a rule whose destination is an ASG applies only to interfaces that are members of it. Table 2.1 lists the resources.

Table 2.1: Resources built in Lab 2

Resource	Name	Details
Resource group	AZ500LAB07	East US
Virtual network	myVirtualNetwork	10.0.0.0/16, subnet default 10.0.0.0/24
Application security groups	myAsgWebServers, myAsgMgmtServers	Labels for the web and management roles
Network security group	myNsg	Attached to subnet default. Allow-Web-All (priority 100, TCP 80 and 443, source Any, destination myAsgWebServers). Allow-RDP-All (priority 110, TCP 3389, source Any, destination myAsgMgmtServers). Default DenyAllInBound at 65500 drops everything else
Web virtual machine	myVmWeb	Windows Server 2022, private IP 10.0.0.4, public IP 20.127.92.242, member of myAsgWebServers
Management virtual machine	myVMMgmt	Windows Server 2022, private IP 10.0.0.5, public IP 20.106.240.97, member of myAsgMgmtServers

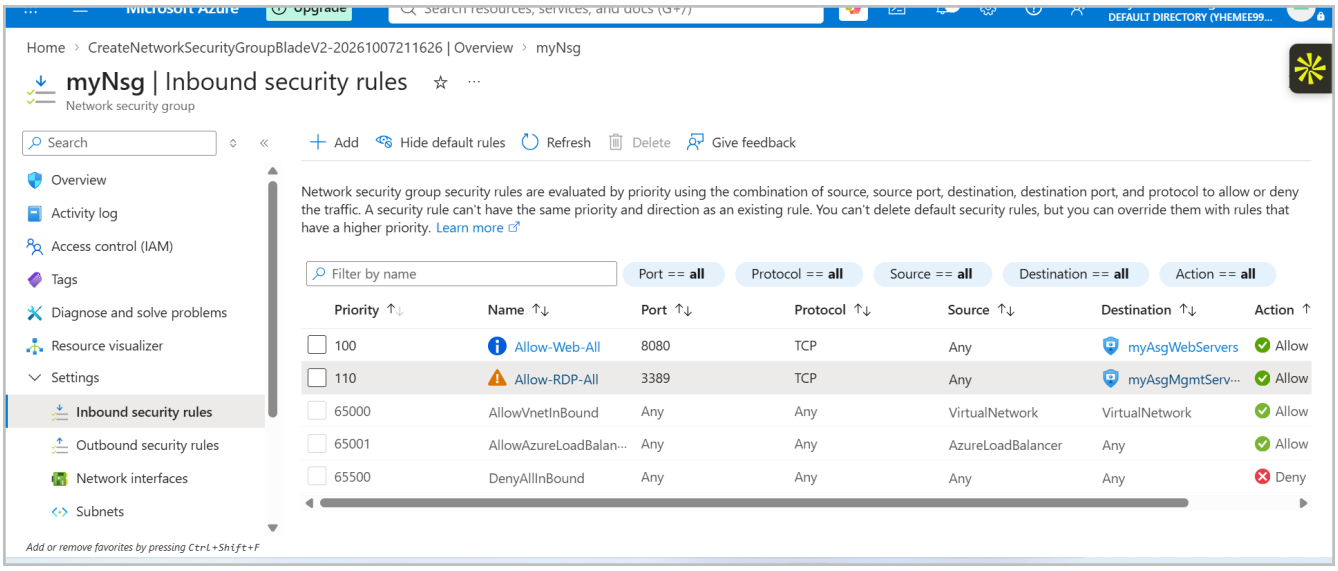


Figure 2.1: Inbound rules on myNsg. Both custom rules target an ASG rather than an IP address. This capture predates the correction of Allow-Web-All from port 8080 to ports 80 and 443 (see 2.4).

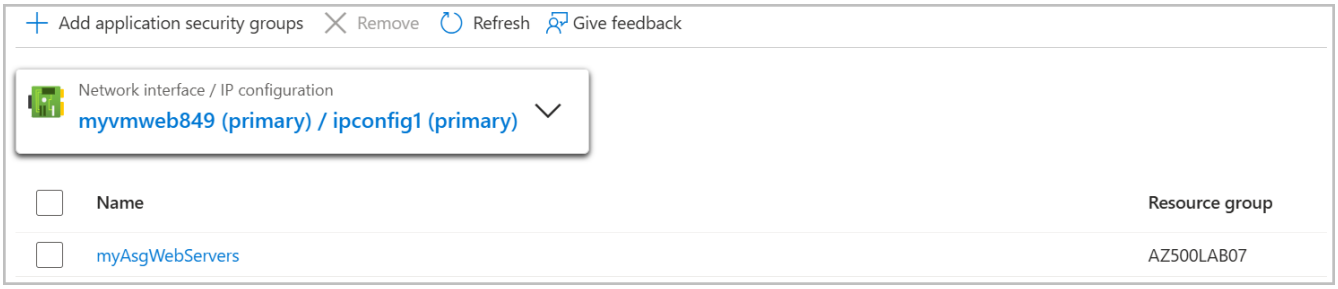


Figure 2.2: The network interface of myVmWeb listed as a member of myAsgWebServers. The equivalent setting placed myVMMgmt in myAsgMgmtServers.

2.3 Tests and results

Four tests were run (Table 2.2). Remote desktop to the management server succeeded, IIS was installed on the web server through Run Command, the IIS welcome page loaded from the internet, and remote desktop to the web server was refused. Run Command succeeded although no rule allows management traffic to the web server, because it runs through the Azure virtual machine agent rather than through the network.

Table 2.2: Tests and results for Lab 2

Test	Expected result	Observed result	Evidence
Remote desktop from the internet to myVMMgmt on TCP 3389	Allowed by Allow-RDP-All	Session established, Server Manager opened	Figure 2.3
Install IIS on myVmWeb with Run Command	Succeeds without a network rule, through the VM agent	Success, no restart required	Figure 2.4 (page served afterwards)
HTTP from the internet to myVmWeb on TCP 80	Allowed by Allow-Web-All	IIS welcome page loaded	Figure 2.4
Remote desktop from the internet to myVmWeb on TCP 3389	Refused, no rule for the web ASG	Remote Desktop could not connect	Figure 2.5

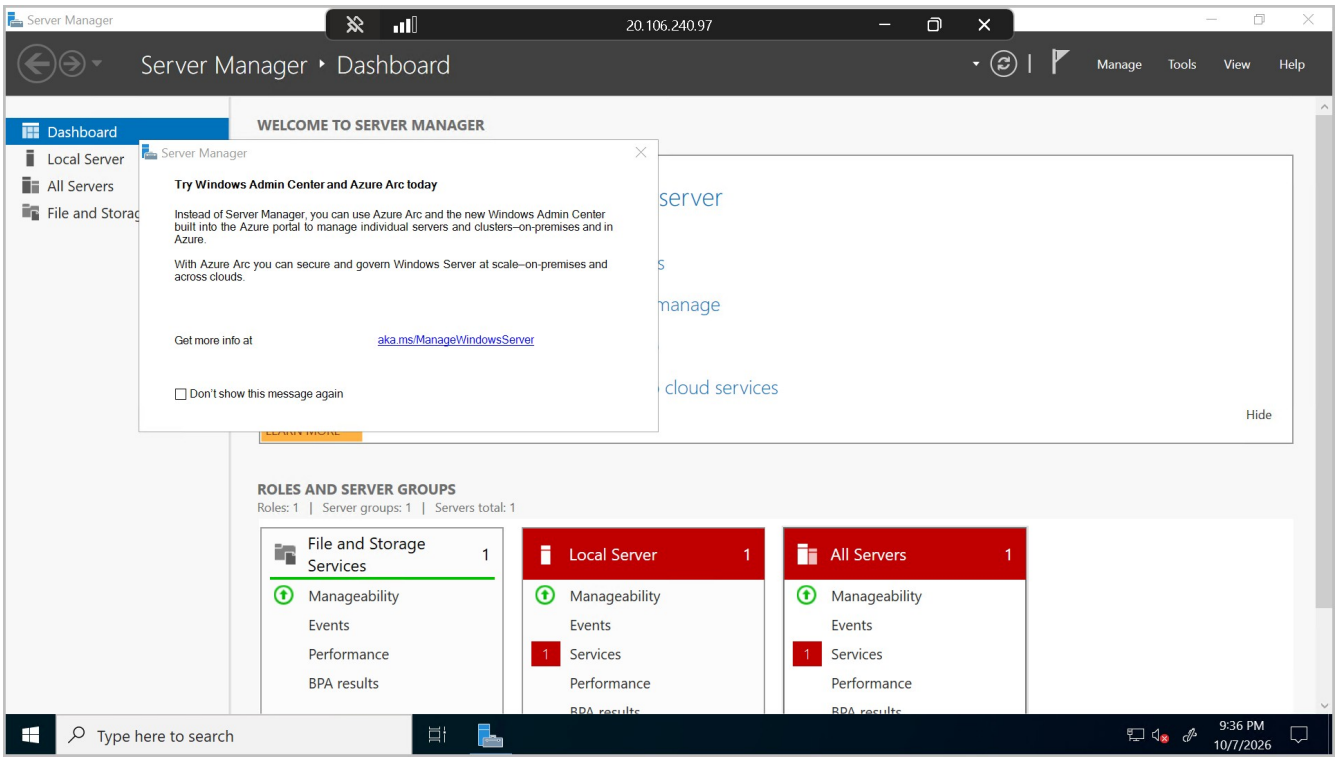


Figure 2.3: Remote desktop session to myVMMgmt at 20.106.240.97 with Server Manager open. Allow-RDP-All permitted the connection because the interface belongs to myAsgMgmtServers.

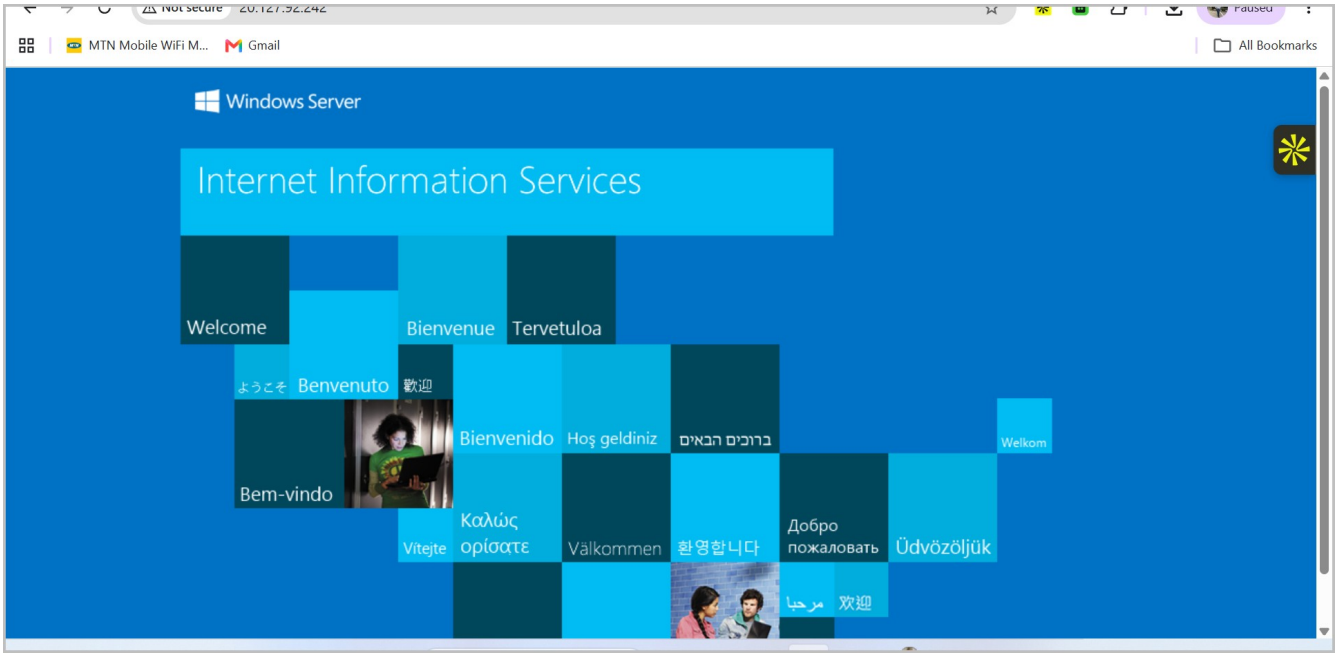


Figure 2.4: The IIS welcome page served by myVmWeb at http://20.127.92.242. Allow-Web-All permitted port 80 to the web ASG.

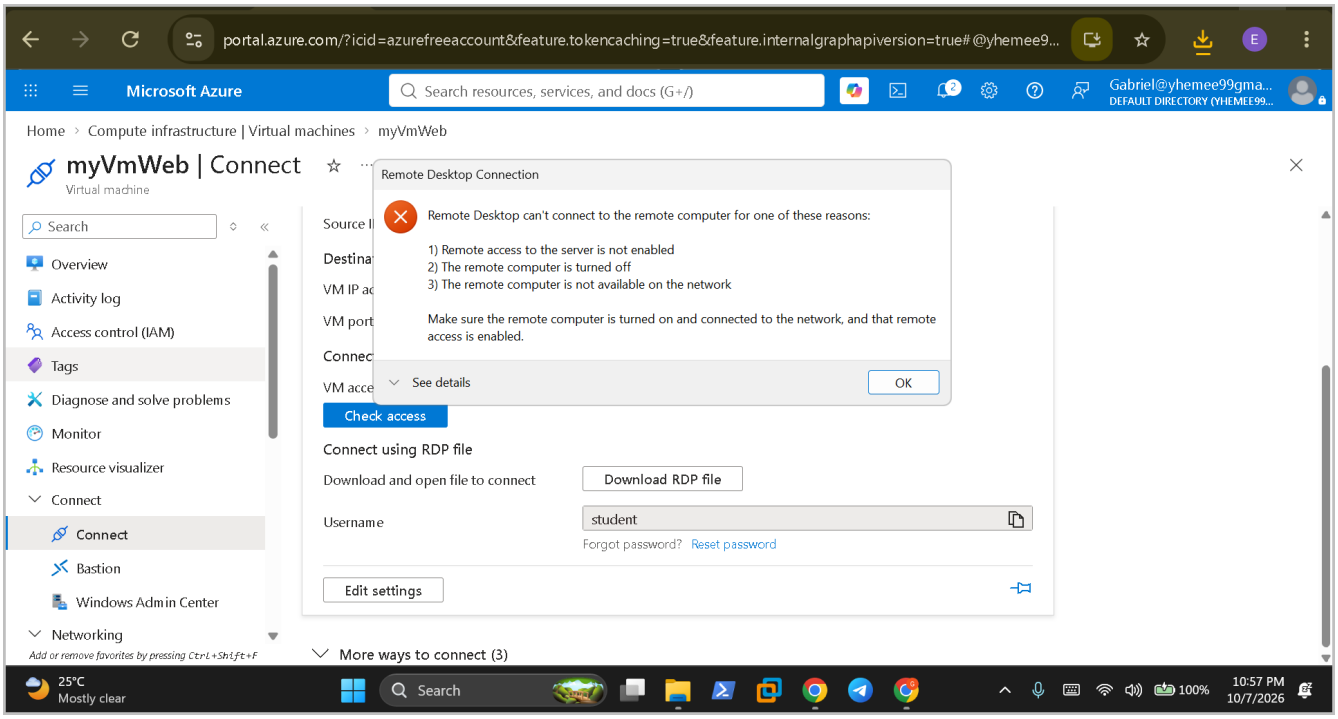


Figure 2.5: Remote desktop to myVmWeb refused. No rule allows TCP 3389 to myAsgWebServers, so the default DenyAllInBound rule dropped the connection.

2.4 Issues and resolutions

The virtual machine size specified in the lab, Standard_D2s_v3, was reported as NotAvailableForSubscription in East US. Free-trial subscriptions cannot use many sizes in busy regions, and another 2 vCPU size was selected from the full size list. The first version of Allow-Web-All was saved with destination port 8080 instead of 80 and 443 (Figure 2.1). The rule was corrected before the web test, after which the IIS page loaded on port 80. The lab text also refers to a provided resource group that does not exist in a new subscription, so AZ500LAB07 was created first.

2.5 Conclusion

One NSG allowed remote desktop to one server and refused it to another on the basis of ASG membership alone, which is network segmentation by role. Two points carry over to StashingFintech. Allowing remote desktop from any source is a lab shortcut; in production the source should be restricted, or management access should go through Azure Bastion or just-in-time access (Section 8). Run Command showed that the network is not the only route into a server, since anyone with the right Azure role can run scripts on a virtual machine without passing the NSG, so Azure role assignments deserve the same scrutiny as firewall rules.

3. Azure Firewall

3.1 Objective

The objective was to deploy Azure Firewall, route the outbound traffic of a workload subnet through it, and apply rules that permit approved web traffic and DNS while blocking every other destination. The lab environment was deployed from an Azure Resource Manager template that provides the virtual network, a workload virtual machine and a jump host.

3.2 Configuration

Table 3.1 lists the configuration. The route table forces all traffic from the workload subnet to the firewall's private address. An application rule allows HTTP and HTTPS to www.bing.com, and a network rule allows DNS queries over UDP 53 to two external resolvers, which the workload virtual machine was configured to use.

Table 3.1: Configuration built in Lab 3

Component	Name	Details
Resource group	AZ500LAB08	East US
Template deployment	template.json	Virtual network Test-FW-VN with Workload-SN, Jump-SN and AzureFirewallSubnet; virtual machines Srv-Work and Srv-Jump
Firewall	Test-FW01	Standard SKU, classic rules, private IP 10.0.1.4, public IP TEST-FW-PIP
Route table	Firewall-route	Associated with Workload-SN. Route FW-DG: 0.0.0.0/0, next hop Virtual appliance 10.0.1.4
Application rule collection	App-Coll01 (priority 200, Allow)	Rule AllowGH: source 10.0.2.0/24, HTTP and HTTPS to www.bing.com
Network rule collection	Net-Coll01 (priority 200, Allow)	Rule AllowDNS: UDP from 10.0.2.0/24 to 209.244.0.3 and 209.244.0.4, port 53
Workload DNS	Srv-Work network interface	Custom DNS servers 209.244.0.3 and 209.244.0.4

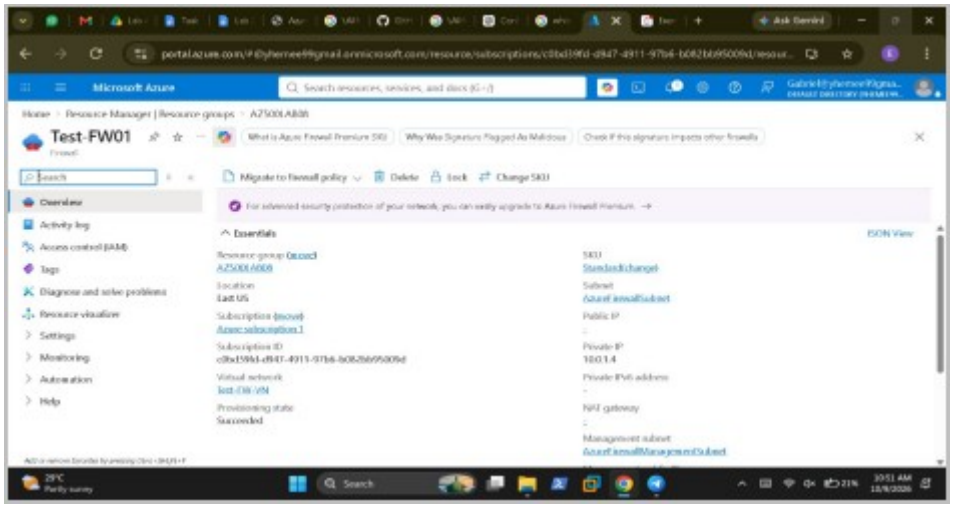


Figure 3.1: Overview of Test-FW01 in AZ500LAB08. Standard SKU, provisioning state Succeeded, private IP address 10.0.1.4, which becomes the next hop for the workload subnet.

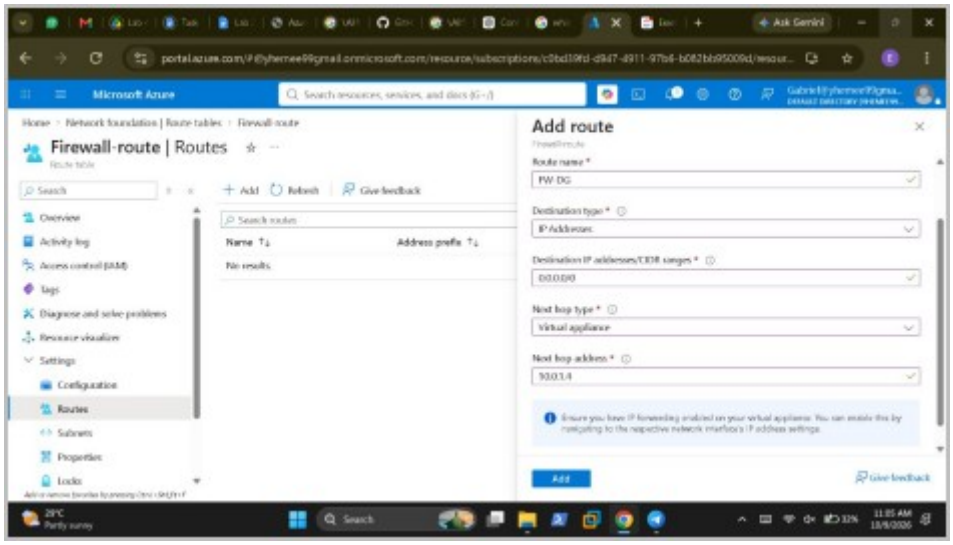


Figure 3.2: Route FW-DG added to the Firewall-route table. Destination 0.0.0.0/0, next hop type Virtual appliance, next hop address 10.0.1.4.

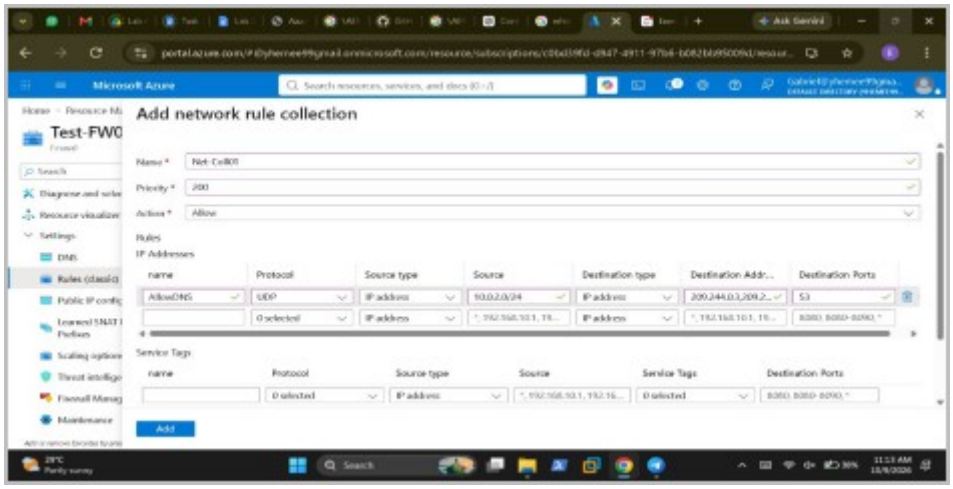


Figure 3.3: Network rule collection Net-Coll01 with rule AllowDNS. UDP from 10.0.2.0/24 to 209.244.0.3 and 209.244.0.4 on port 53, priority 200, action Allow.

3.3 Tests and results

The tests were run from Srv-Work through a remote desktop session nested in Srv-Jump, after Internet Explorer Enhanced Security Configuration had been switched off. Browsing to www.bing.com succeeded and browsing to www.microsoft.com returned the firewall's deny page (Table 3.2). Name resolution worked for both sites, which shows that the DNS network rule was in effect.

Table 3.2: Tests and results for Lab 3

Test	Expected result	Observed result	Evidence
Browse https://www.bing.com from Srv-Work	Allowed by application rule AllowGH	Page loaded	Figure 3.4
Browse http://www.microsoft.com from Srv-Work	Blocked, no matching rule	Firewall response: Action Deny, Reason No rule matched	Figure 3.5
Resolve both names from Srv-Work	Allowed by network rule AllowDNS	Names resolved	Implied by Figures 3.4 and 3.5

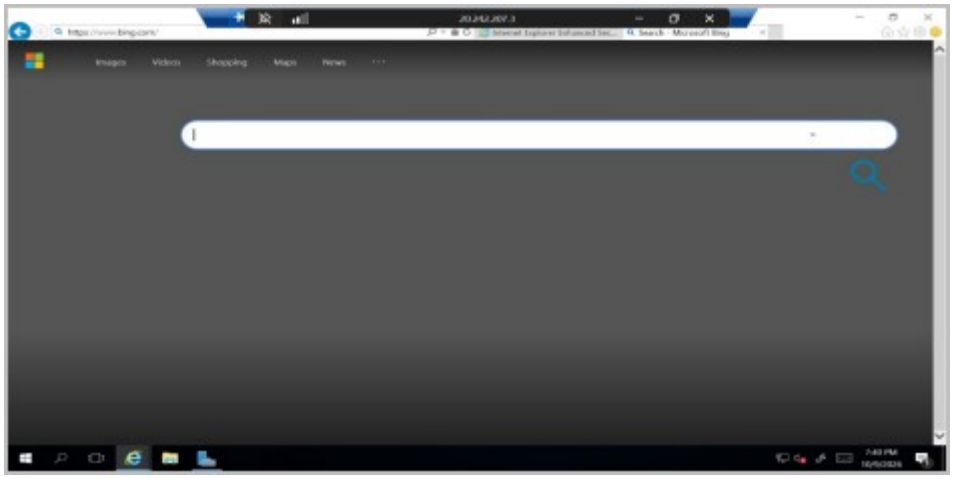


Figure 3.4: www.bing.com loaded in Internet Explorer on Srv-Work. The application rule permitted the request through the firewall.



Figure 3.5: www.microsoft.com blocked on Srv-Work. The browser shows the firewall message Action: Deny. Reason: No rule matched. Proceeding with default action.

3.4 Issues and resolutions

The template referenced by the lab was no longer available in Microsoft's repository. A copy was located in a third-party repository and edited before use: the hard-coded administrator password was removed and the virtual machine size was changed to Standard_D2s_v4 after the original size failed validation on the free-trial subscription. A second deployment error was traced to the firewall's public IP address, which the template defined with the Basic SKU and dynamic allocation. Azure Firewall requires a Standard SKU public IP with static allocation, so the template's sku name was changed to Standard and publicIPAllocationMethod to Static, after which the deployment completed.

3.5 Conclusion

Routing and firewall rules worked together to permit only approved outbound destinations and the DNS service needed to reach them. For StashingFintech this is the pattern for workloads that must reach a small set of external services and nothing else. The lab also showed a supply chain risk: the template came from a third party's repository and contained a hard-coded password. Templates should come from trusted or internally hosted sources and be reviewed for embedded secrets before deployment.

4. Azure Container Registry and Azure Kubernetes Service

4.1 Objective

The objective was to create a private container registry, store an nginx image in it, deploy an Azure Kubernetes Service (AKS) cluster that can pull from that registry, and publish the image twice: on a public load balancer reachable from the internet and on an internal load balancer reachable only inside the cluster's virtual network. The lab exercises the permissions that connect the registry, the cluster identity and the network.

4.2 Configuration

The resource group AZ500LAB09 holds the registry and the cluster. AKS created a second, managed resource group for the node scale set, the load balancers and the cluster virtual network. Two role assignments make the deployment work: the cluster's kubelet identity holds AcrPull on the registry, so nodes pull images without any stored credential, and the cluster's managed identity holds Contributor on the cluster virtual network, so it can create an internal load balancer there. Table 4.1 lists the resources.

Table 4.1: Resources built in Lab 4

Resource	Name	Details
Resource group	AZ500LAB09	Created with az group create in East US
Container registry	az5001951514877	Basic SKU. Repository sample/nginx, tag v1, imported from docker.io/library/nginx:latest
AKS cluster	MyKubernetesCluster	Dev/Test preset, Free tier, local accounts with Kubernetes RBAC, Azure CNI Overlay, two nodes, Kubernetes 1.35.8, West US 2
Node resource group	MC_AZ500LAB09_MyKubernetesCluster_eastus	Created by AKS. Holds the nodes, the load balancers and the virtual network aks-vnet-30198516 (10.224.0.0/12)
Role assignments	AcrPull, Contributor	Kubelet identity: AcrPull on the registry. Cluster identity: Contributor on aks-vnet-30198516
Public service	nginxexternal	Type LoadBalancer, public IP 20.69.138.130, port 80
Internal service	nginxinternal	Type LoadBalancer with the azure-load-balancer-internal annotation, private IP 10.224.0.6, port 80

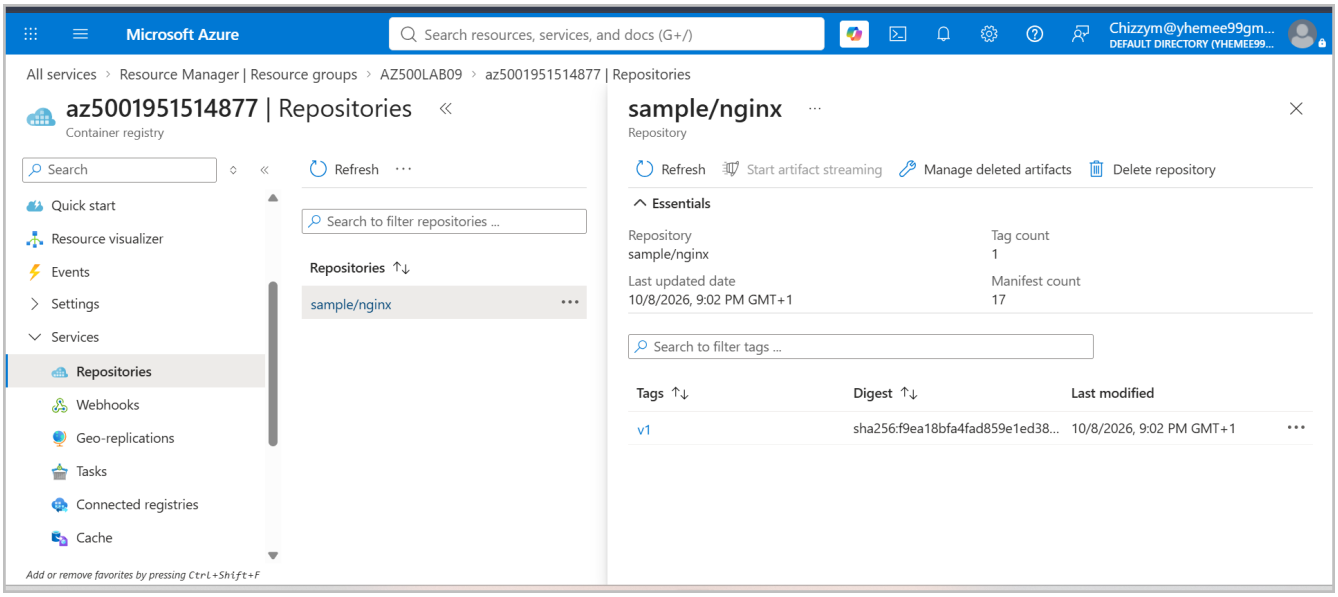


Figure 4.1: The registry az5001951514877 in the portal. Repository sample/nginx holds one tag, v1.

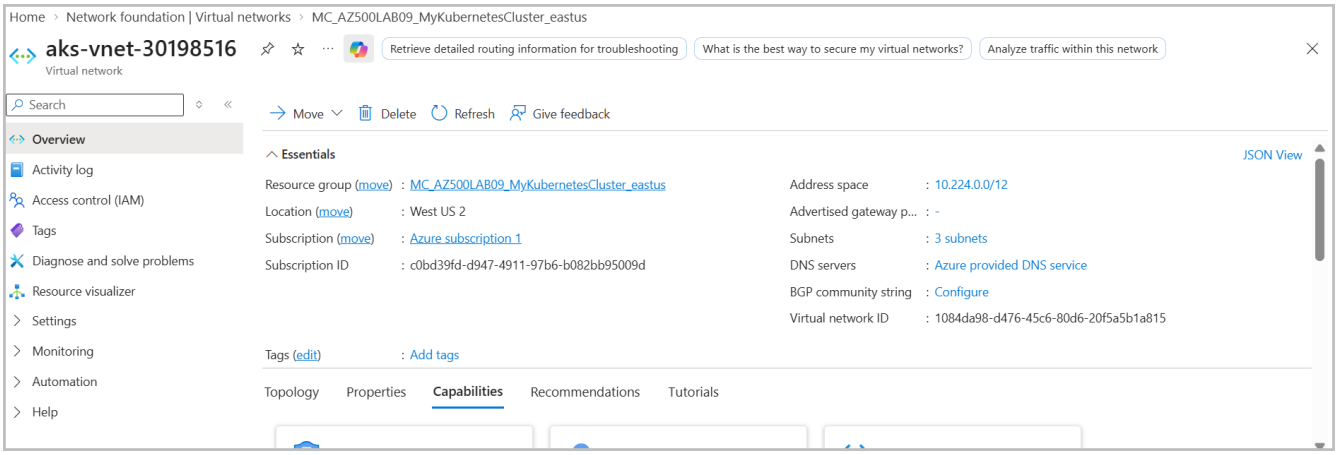


Figure 4.2: Cloud Shell after az aks get-credentials. Two nodes report Ready on Kubernetes 1.35.8, and az aks update --attach-acr grants the cluster the AcrPull role on the registry.

4.3 Tests and results

Four tests were run (Table 4.2). The cluster pulled the image from the private registry and served it on the public address. The internal address timed out from a laptop, as it should, and responded to curl from inside a pod in the cluster.

Table 4.2: Tests and results for Lab 4

Test	Expected result	Observed result	Evidence
kubectl get nodes after retrieving the cluster credentials	Nodes in Ready state	Two nodes Ready	Figure 4.2
Browse http://20.69.138.130 from the internet	nginx welcome page	Page loaded	Figure 4.3
Browse http://10.224.0.6 from a laptop	No response, the address exists only inside the virtual network	ERR_CONNECTION_TIMED_OUT	Figure 4.4
curl http://10.224.0.6 from inside the nginxexternal pod	nginx HTML	Welcome to nginx HTML returned	Figure 4.5

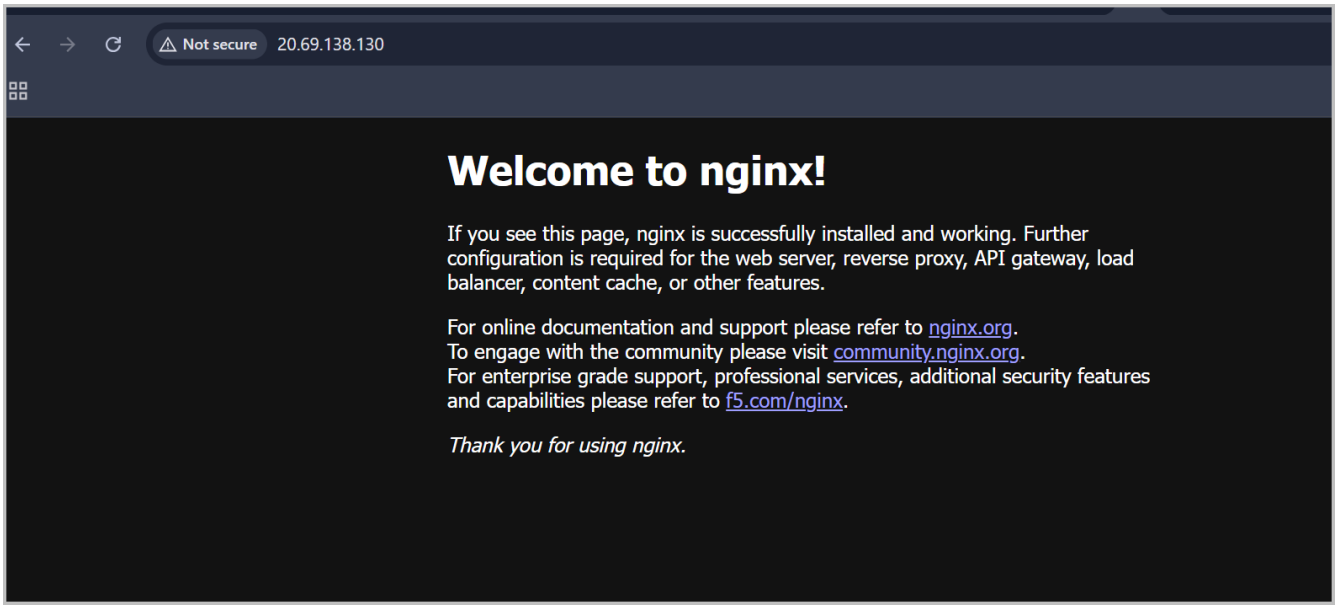


Figure 4.3: The nginx welcome page at http://20.69.138.130, served by a pod running the image pulled from the private registry through the public load balancer.

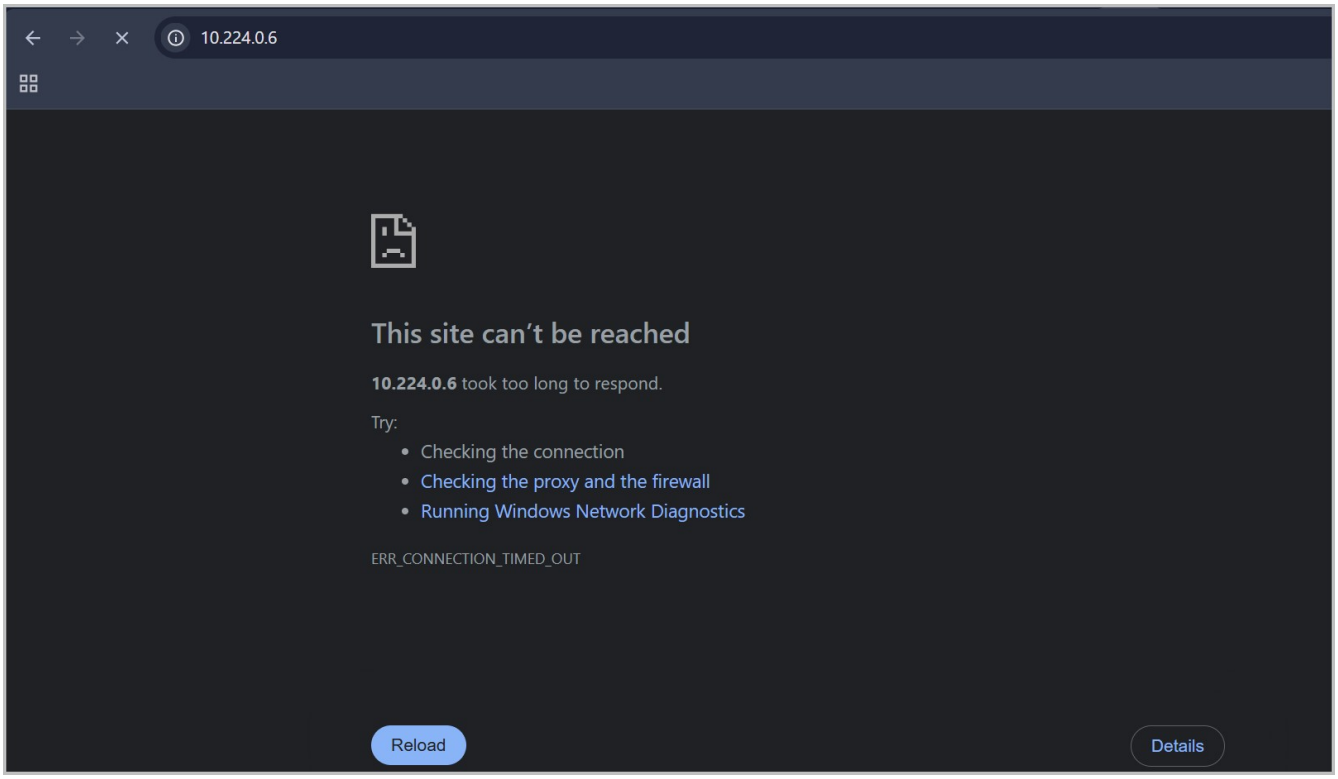


Figure 4.4: The internal address 10.224.0.6 times out from a laptop. The internal load balancer is reachable only inside the virtual network.

```
chizzym [ ~ ]$ kubectl exec -it nginxexternal-7f75b447c5-kxp75 -- /bin/bash
root@nginxexternal-7f75b447c5-kxp75:/# curl http://10.224.0.6
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<head>
<title>Welcome to nginx!</title>
<style>
html { color-scheme: light dark; }
body { width: 35em; margin: 0 auto;
font-family: Tahoma, Verdana, Arial, sans-serif; }
</style>
</head>
<body>
<h1>Welcome to nginx!</h1>
<p>If you see this page, nginx is successfully installed and working.
Further configuration is required for the web server, reverse proxy,
API gateway, load balancer, content cache, or other features.</p>

<p>For online documentation and support please refer to
<a href="https://nginx.org/">nginx.org</a>.<br/>
To engage with the community please visit
<a href="https://community.nginx.org/">community.nginx.org</a>.<br/>
For enterprise grade support, professional services, additional
security features and capabilities please refer to
<a href="https://f5.com/nginx">f5.com/nginx</a>.</p>

<p><em>Thank you for using nginx.</em></p>
</body>
</html>
root@nginxexternal-7f75b447c5-kxp75:/#
```

Figure 4.5: curl to http://10.224.0.6 from inside the nginxexternal pod returns the nginx welcome page, which proves the internal service works where it is meant to.

4.4 Issues and resolutions

Five issues arose. First, az acr build returned TasksOperationsNotAllowed, because Azure Container Registry Tasks are not permitted on this subscription type, and Cloud Shell has no Docker daemon for a local build. The official nginx image was imported from Docker Hub into the registry with az acr import under the name the lab expects, sample/nginx:v1. Second, the default node size Standard_DS2_v2 was unavailable for the subscription; the node size and region were changed until validation passed, and the cluster was created in West US 2 with two nodes. Third, the two YAML files referenced by the lab no longer exist in Microsoft's repository, so they were typed into Cloud Shell from the lab text, and a pasted block lost some line breaks. Fourth, the lab instructs the reader to replace line 24 with the registry name; in the hand-typed file line 24 held the service name rather than the image, so the public service was created with the registry's name and no matching pods. The line was restored with sed, the misnamed service deleted and the file re-applied. Fifth, repeated create commands left four registries in the resource group and the attach command failed because the shell variable held four names; the three empty registries were deleted.

4.5 Conclusion

The cluster never needed a registry password, because the pull happens through a managed identity and a role assignment. That is the pattern to follow wherever a credential would otherwise sit in configuration. The only difference between the public and the private service was one annotation, which shows how a single missing line can place an internal application on the internet, so service manifests deserve review before deployment. Both resource groups were deleted at the end of the lab.

5. Service endpoints and securing storage

5.1 Objective

The objective was to restrict a storage account to a single subnet with a service endpoint and the storage firewall, and to restrict that subnet's outbound traffic with a network security group so that it can reach Azure Storage but not the internet. A second subnet without those controls allows a direct comparison, and two virtual machines, one in each subnet, run the same tests.

5.2 Configuration

The resource group AZ500LAB12 holds one virtual network with Public and Private subnets, two network security groups, one storage account with a file share and two Windows Server virtual machines. The Private subnet has the Microsoft.Storage service endpoint enabled, and the storage account accepts traffic from that subnet only. Table 5.1 lists the configuration.

Table 5.1: Configuration built in Lab 5

Resource	Name	Details
Resource group	AZ500LAB12	East US
Virtual network	myVirtualNetwork	10.0.0.0/16. Subnet Public 10.0.0.0/24. Subnet Private 10.0.1.0/24 with the Microsoft.Storage service endpoint
NSG on Private	myNsgPrivate	Outbound: Allow-Storage-All (1000, VirtualNetwork to Storage service tag, Allow), Deny-Internet-All (1100, VirtualNetwork to Internet service tag, Deny). Inbound: Allow-RDP-All (1200)
NSG on Public	myNsgPublic	Inbound Allow-RDP-All (1200) only
Storage account	az500lab12pc111	General purpose v2, locally redundant storage, file share my-file-share. Public network access from selected networks: myVirtualNetwork / Private only
Private virtual machine	myVmPrivate	Windows Server, subnet Private, private IP 10.0.1.4, public IP 20.115.2.8
Public virtual machine	myVmPublic	Windows Server, subnet Public, private IP 10.0.0.4, public IP 40.121.19.45

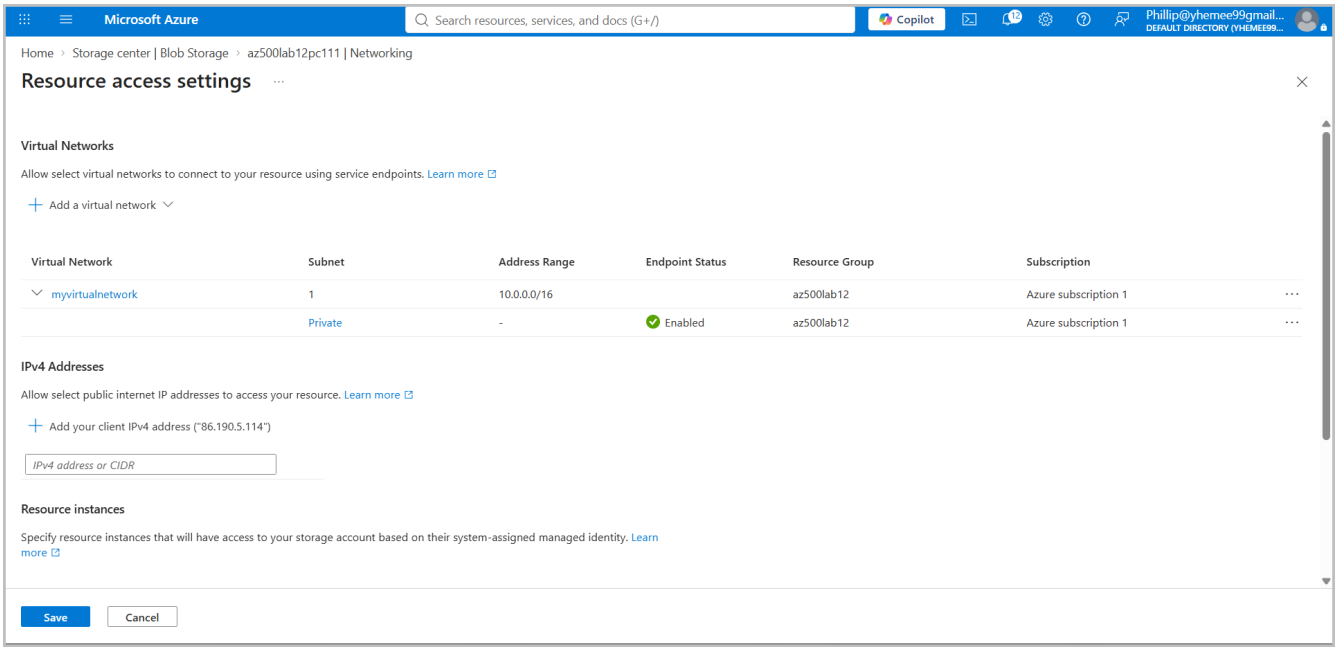


Figure 5.1: Resource access settings of the storage account. myVirtualNetwork / Private is the only network allowed, and its endpoint status is Enabled.

5.3 Tests and results

The same two commands were run on each virtual machine: the connect script generated by the portal for the file share, which checks port 445, stores the storage key and maps the share as drive Z, and Test-NetConnection against www.bing.com on port 80. Table 5.2 shows the results. The outcomes were the mirror image of each other, and the only variable was the subnet in which the virtual machine sits.

Table 5.2: Tests and results for Lab 5

Test	Expected result	Observed result	Evidence
Map my-file-share as drive Z from myVmPrivate	Drive maps; the Private subnet is allowed through the storage firewall	Drive Z mapped with 1 TB free, visible in File Explorer	Figure 5.2
Test-NetConnection www.bing.com port 80 from myVmPrivate	Blocked by Deny-Internet-All	All TCP connections failed, TcpTestSucceeded False	Figure 5.3
Map my-file-share as drive Z from myVmPublic	Refused; the Public subnet is not allowed by the storage firewall	New-PSDrive: Access is denied	Figure 5.4
Test-NetConnection www.bing.com port 80 from myVmPublic	Allowed; myNsgPublic has no deny rule	TcpTestSucceeded True	Figure 5.4

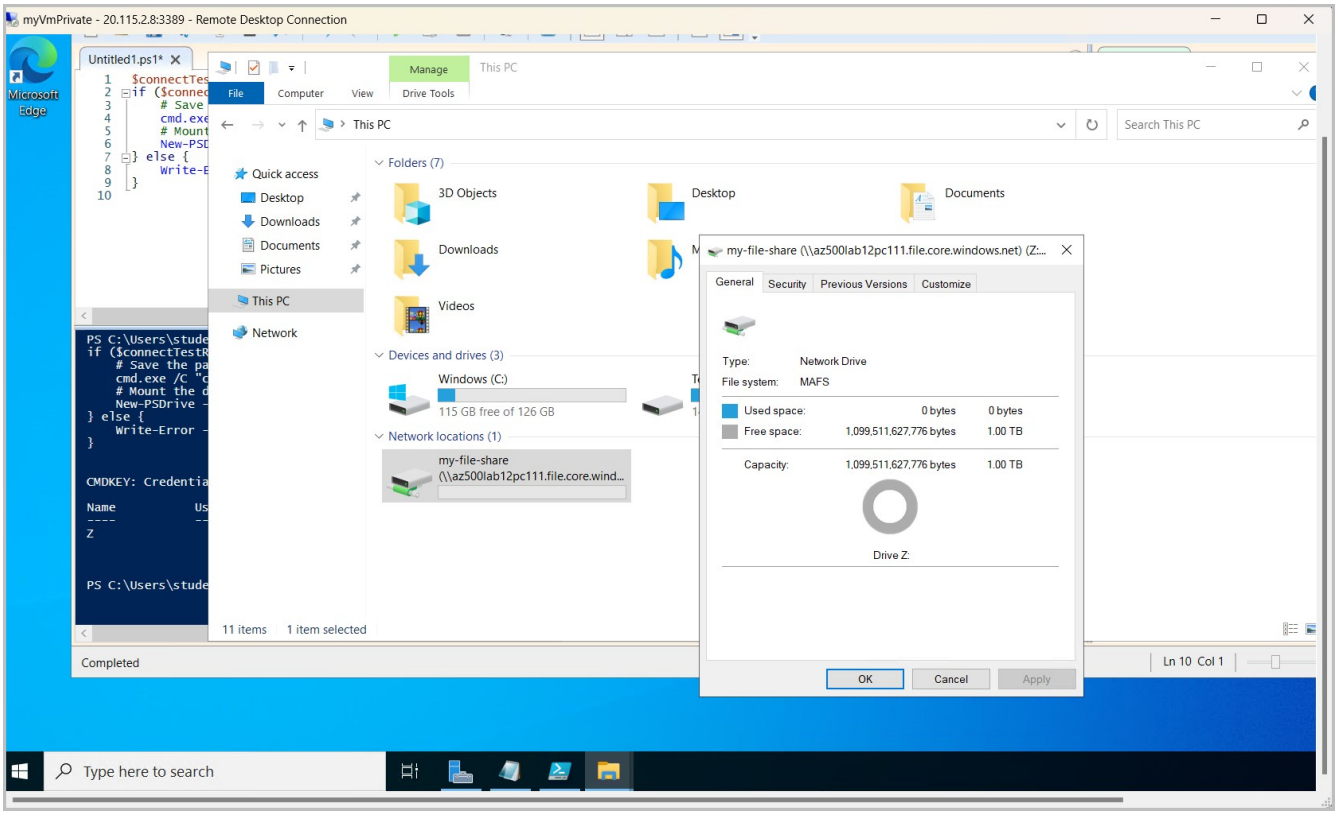


Figure 5.2: On myVmPrivate the connect script mapped my-file-share as drive Z, shown in File Explorer under Network locations with 1 TB capacity.

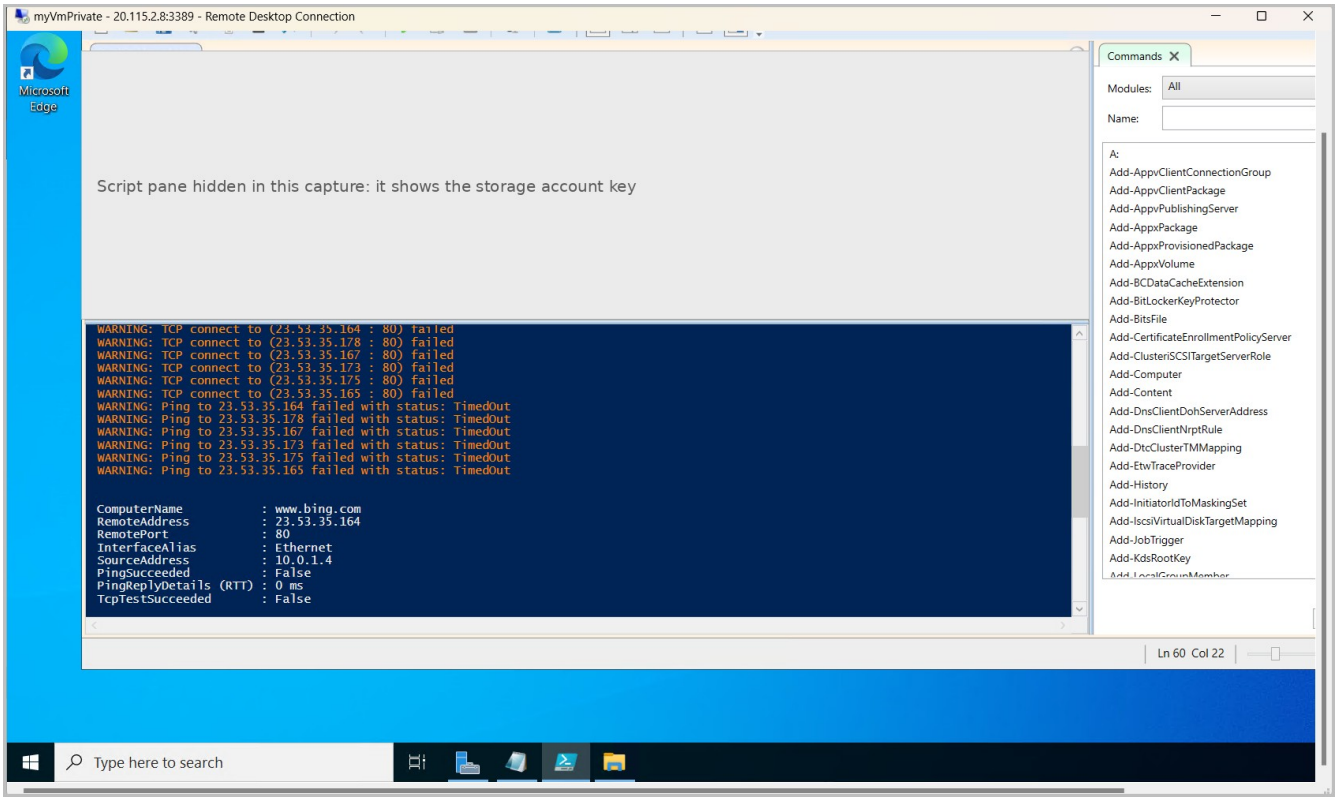


Figure 5.3: On myVmPrivate every TCP connection to www.bing.com on port 80 failed and TcpTestSucceeded is False. The script pane is hidden because it contains the storage account key.

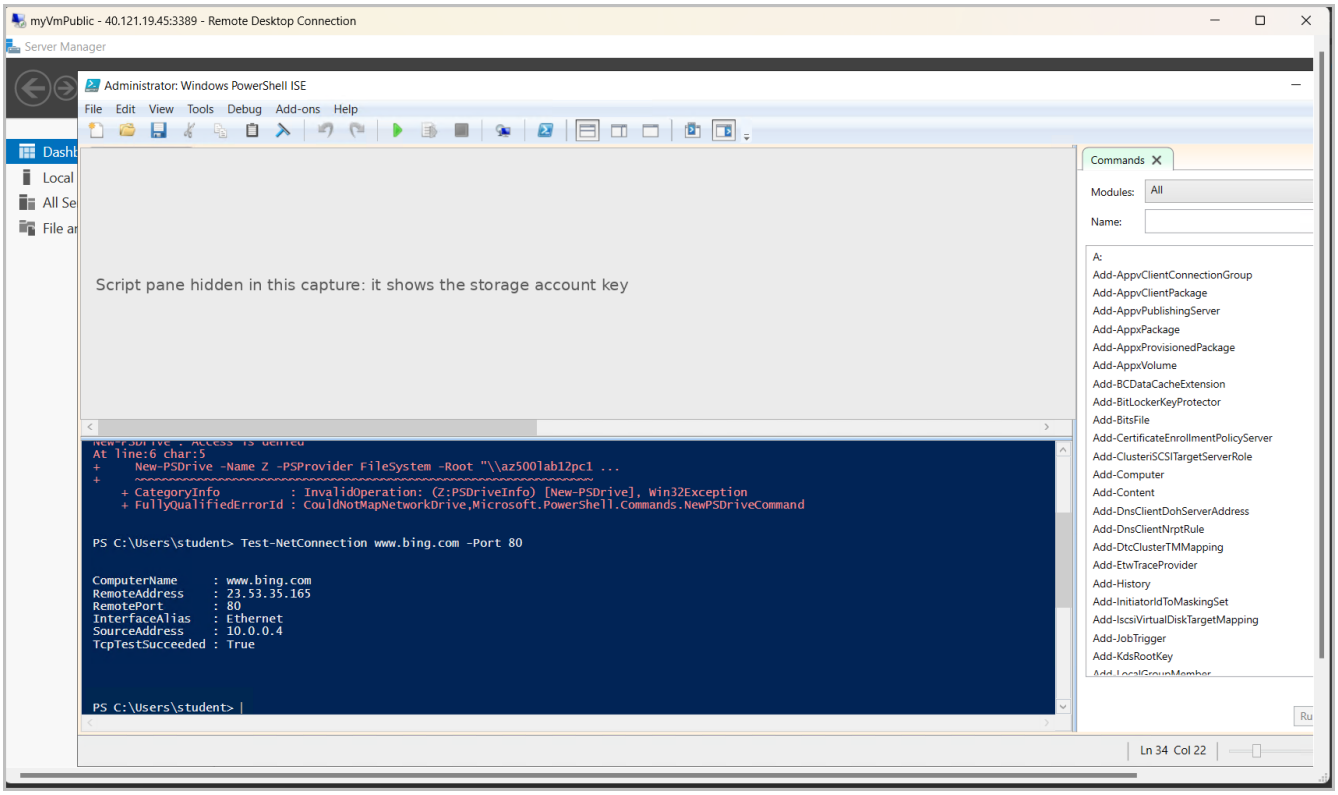


Figure 5.4: On myVmPublic New-PSDrive fails with Access is denied, while Test-NetConnection to www.bing.com returns TcpTestSucceeded True. The script pane is hidden for the same reason.

5.4 Issues and resolutions

The first remote desktop attempt to myVmPrivate timed out with error 0x204. The network settings of the virtual machine showed myNsgPrivate with only the three default inbound rules, so the Allow-RDP-All rule was added and the session then opened. The first internet test from myVmPrivate returned True, the opposite of the expected result. The rule Deny-Internet-All had been saved with its action set to Allow. The action was corrected to Deny and the test was repeated with the expected result (Figure 5.3). Both errors were found by testing rather than by reading the rule list, which is why the recommendations call for a second person to confirm each rule’s action, port and priority before it is saved.

5.5 Conclusion

Two independent controls were at work and the tests told them apart. The storage firewall with the service endpoint decided which subnet could open the share, which is what refused myVmPublic. The network security group decided what the Private subnet could reach, which is what blocked the internet test. Either control alone would leave a gap. The connect script contains the storage account key in clear text; it must be kept out of documents and screenshots, and identity-based access or shared access signatures should replace account keys wherever possible. The resource group was deleted at the end of the lab, which retired the key with the account.

6. Log Analytics workspace, storage account and data collection rule

6.1 Objective

The objective was to build the collection layer for the monitoring labs: a virtual machine to monitor, a Log Analytics workspace to hold its data, a storage account for diagnostic data, and a data collection rule that uses the Azure Monitor Agent to send performance counters from the virtual machine to the workspace. Labs 7, 8 and 9 reuse this environment.

6.2 Configuration

The resource group and the virtual machine were created in Cloud Shell with PowerShell, and the remaining resources in the portal. Table 6.1 lists the configuration.

Table 6.1: Resources built in Lab 6

Resource	Name	Details
Resource group	AZ500LAB131415	East US, created with New-AzResourceGroup. The EncryptionAtHost feature was registered on the subscription
Virtual machine	myVM	Windows, Standard_D2_v4, created with New-AzVm in virtual network myVnet, subnet mySubnet, with network security group myNetworkSecurityGroup, a Standard public IP and ports 80 and 3389 open
Log Analytics workspace	lgawIgnite	East US, in AZ500LAB131415
Storage account	stashingfintechstorage	StorageV2, East US, for diagnostic and monitoring data
Data collection rule	DCR1	Platform Windows. Data source Performance Counters for CPU, memory, disk and network. Destination Azure Monitor Logs, workspace lgawIgnite

```
PS /home/adesikemi>  Get-AzVM -Name 'myVM' -ResourceGroupName 'AZ500LAB131415' | Format-Table

ResourceGroupName Name Location        VmSize  OsType  NIC ProvisioningState
----------------- ---- --------        ------  ------  --- -----------------
AZ500LAB131415    myVM   eastus Standard_D2_v4 Windows myVM        Succeeded
```

Figure 6.1: Get-AzVM confirms myVM in AZ500LAB131415, size Standard_D2_v4, Windows, provisioning state Succeeded.

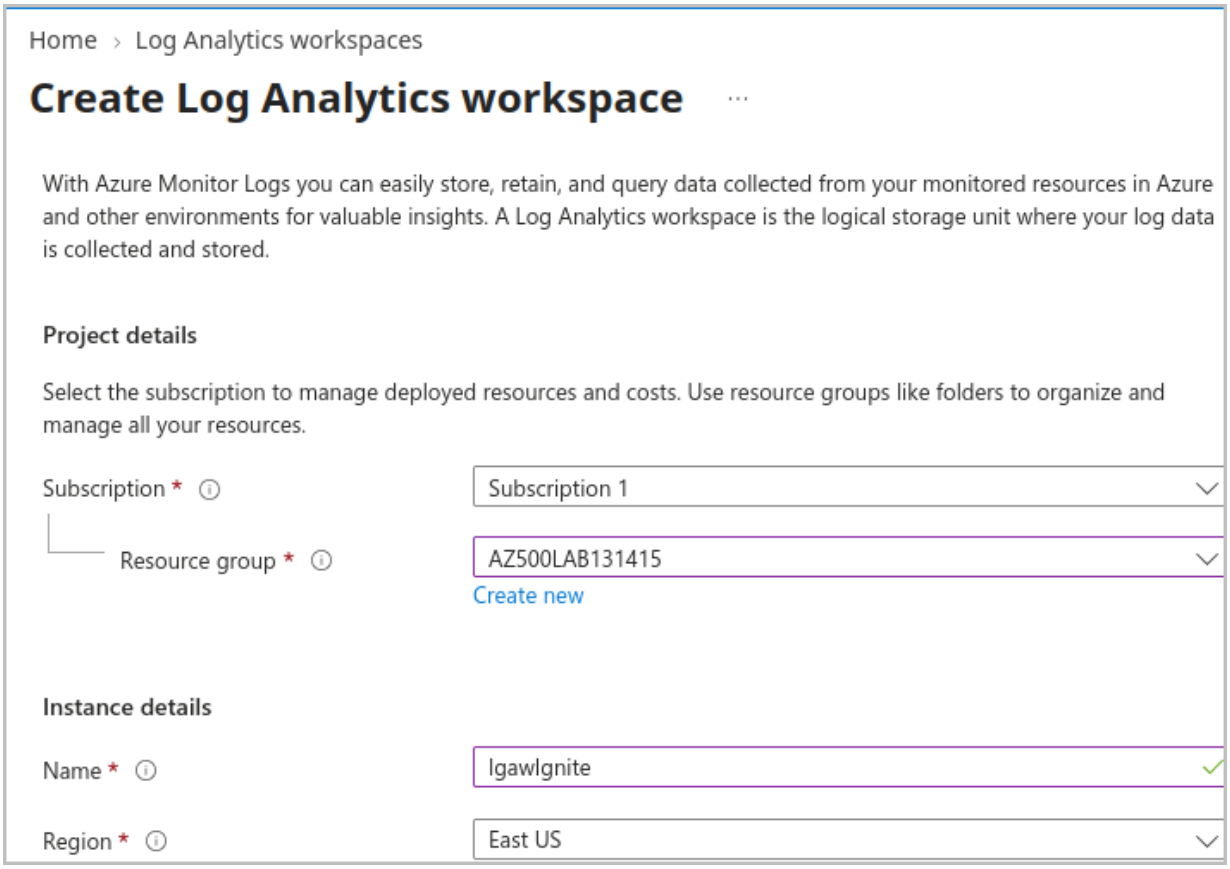


Figure 6.2: The Log Analytics workspace lgawlgnite created in resource group AZ500LAB131415, East US.

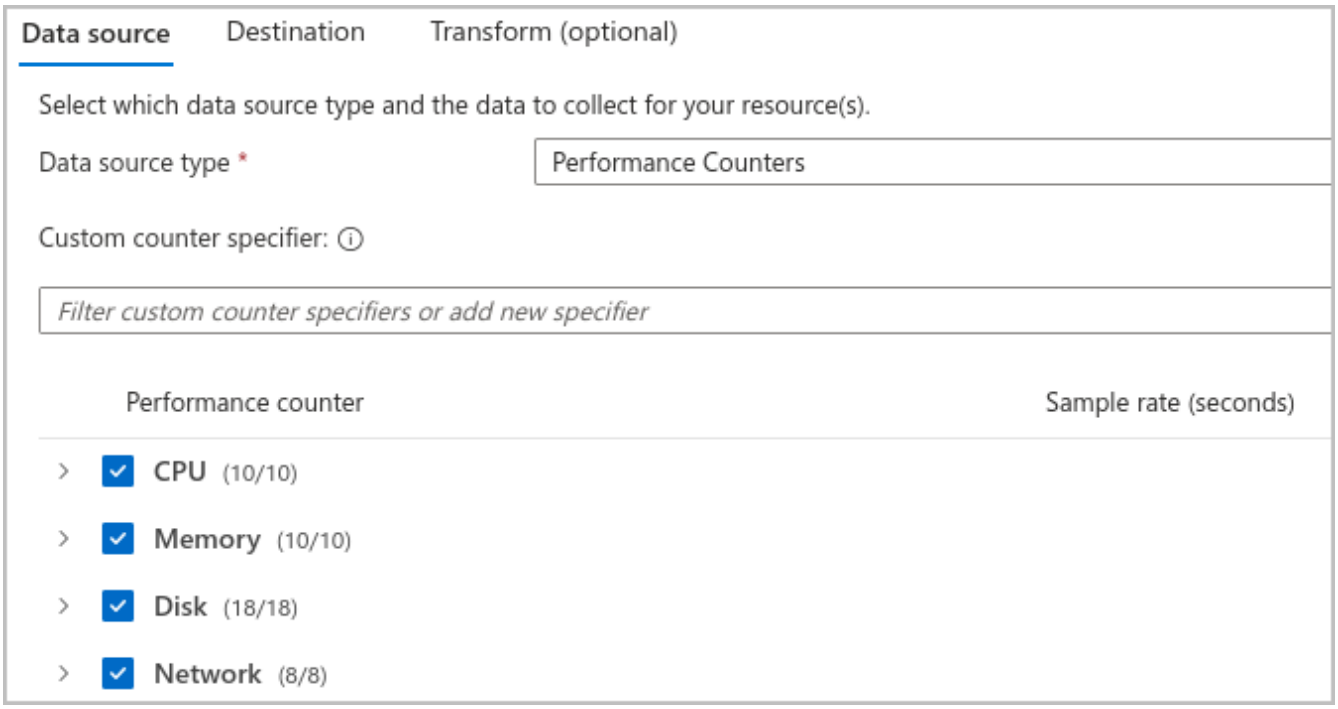


Figure 6.3: Data source of DCR1. Performance counters for CPU, memory, disk and network are selected.

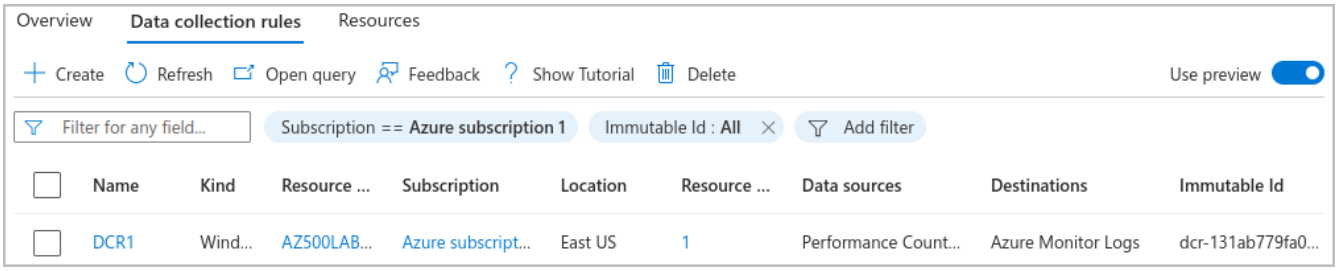


Figure 6.4: DCR1 listed under Data collection rules with data source Performance Counters and destination Azure Monitor Logs.

6.3 Verification

The virtual machine reported provisioning state Succeeded (Figure 6.1), the workspace and storage account were created in the resource group (Figure 6.2), and the data collection rule showed the performance counter data source routed to the workspace (Figures 6.3 and 6.4). This confirmed that the Azure Monitor Agent and the rule were linked and that the specified metrics would flow to lgawIgnite.

6.4 Issues and resolutions

No issues were recorded for this lab.

6.5 Conclusion

The lab established the pipeline that every later detection depends on: an agent on the virtual machine, a rule that says what to collect, and a workspace that holds the data. The resource group was kept until Lab 9 ended, because Defender for Servers, just-in-time access and Sentinel all operate on this virtual machine and workspace.

7. Microsoft Defender for Cloud enhanced security for servers

7.1 Objective

The objective was to enable the Defender for Servers plan in Microsoft Defender for Cloud so that virtual machines in the subscription receive threat protection, vulnerability assessment and the just-in-time access feature used in Lab 8.

7.2 Configuration

In Microsoft Defender for Cloud, under Environment settings, the subscription's Defender plans page was opened and the Servers plan was switched from Off to On and saved. This enables Defender for Servers Plan 2 for every virtual machine in the subscription (Figure 7.1).

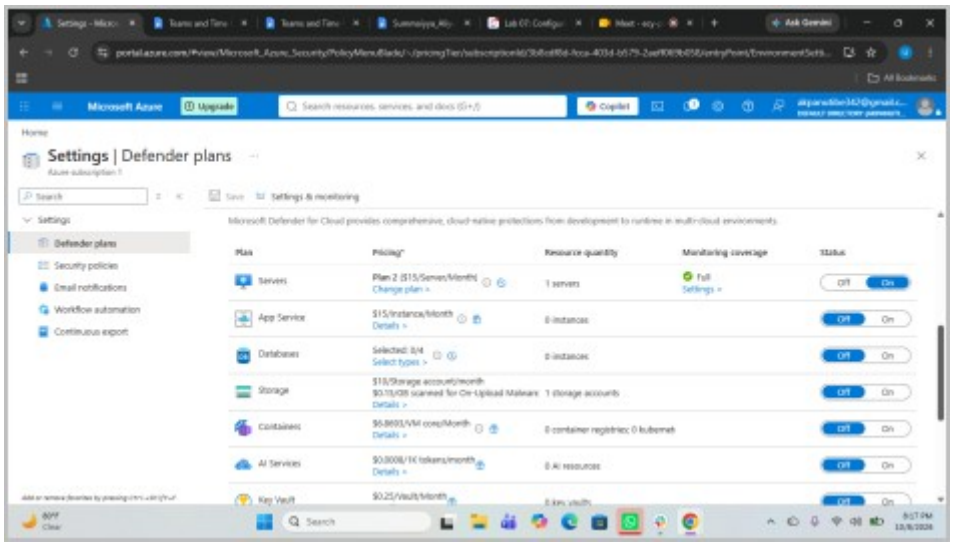


Figure 7.1: Defender plans for the subscription. The Servers plan is On, covering one server, with the other plans left Off.

7.3 Verification

The Defender plans page showed the Servers plan with status On and one server covered, which is myVM from Lab 6. The just-in-time option used in Lab 8 became available on the virtual machine as a result.

7.4 Issues and resolutions

No issues were recorded for this lab. Defender for Servers Plan 2 is billed per server after the first thirty days, which is one reason the lab resources were deleted at the end of the sprint.

7.5 Conclusion

Enabling the plan is a single setting, but it changes the security posture of every server in the subscription by adding continuous monitoring, vulnerability findings and the ability to close management ports by default. For StashingFintech this would be a baseline control for any virtual machine that handles payment data.

8. Just-in-time virtual machine access

8.1 Objective

The objective was to enable just-in-time (JIT) access on myVM so that its management port stays closed until an authorised user requests access for a limited time from a specific address, reducing the exposure of the port to brute-force attacks.

8.2 Configuration

On the Configuration page of myVM, just-in-time access was enabled with the default policy: RDP on TCP 3389, a maximum request duration of three hours and any source IP permitted at request time. The policy was reviewed in Microsoft Defender for Cloud under Workload protections, where myVM appeared as the one configured virtual machine (Figure 8.1). Access was then requested from the Connect page of the virtual machine, which checks the JIT status before offering a connection.

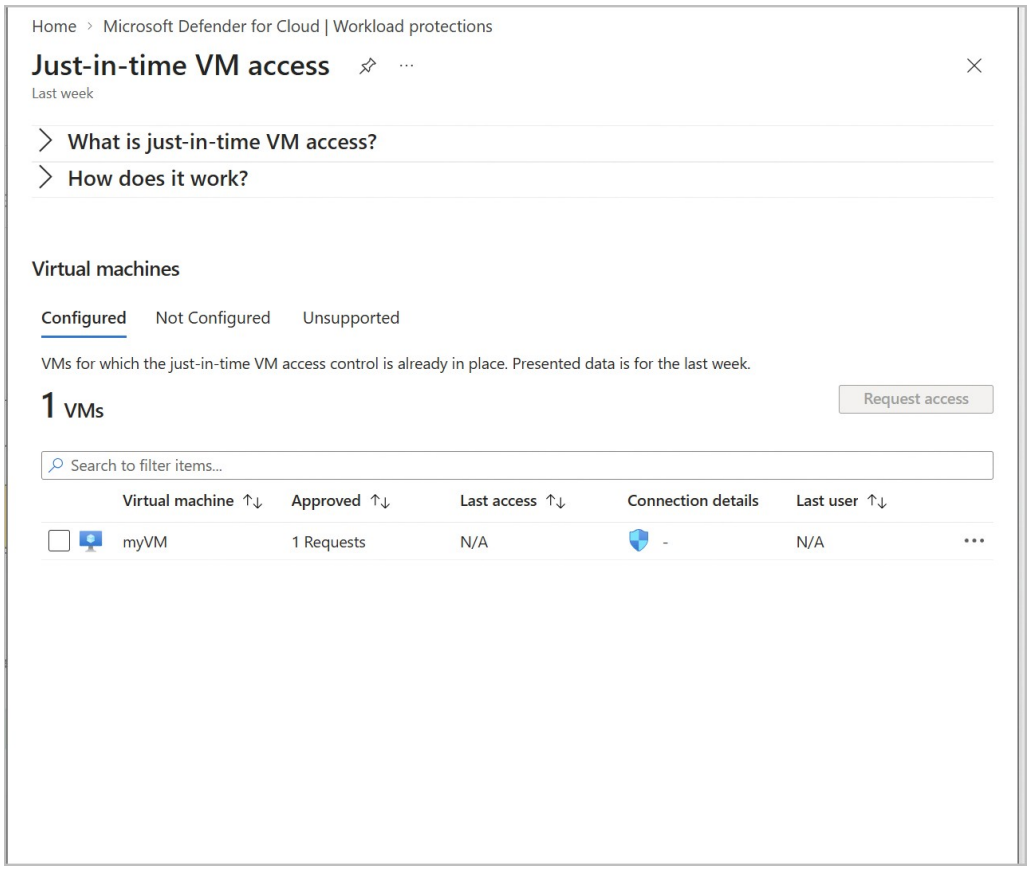


Figure 8.1: Just-in-time VM access in Microsoft Defender for Cloud. myVM is the one configured virtual machine, with one access request recorded.

8.3 Tests and results

After the access request was approved, the Connect page reported that JIT access to port 3389 existed for the requesting IP address and that the port was accessible from that address (Figure 8.2). A remote desktop session to the virtual machine then succeeded. Outside an approved request the network security group keeps port 3389 closed, so continuous open access to the machine was removed.

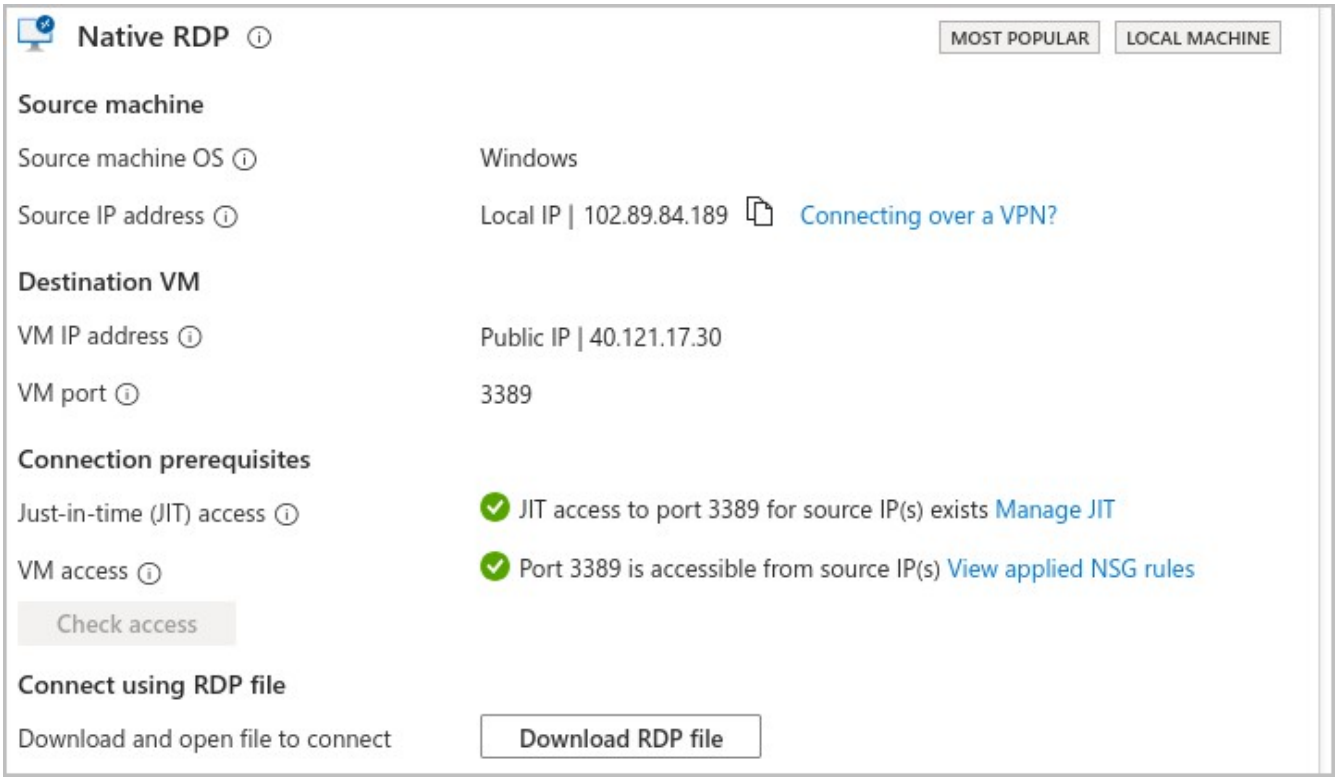


Figure 8.2: Connection prerequisites on the Connect page of myVM after the request. JIT access to port 3389 exists for the source IP and the port is accessible from that address only.

8.4 Issues and resolutions

No issues were recorded for this lab. The integration between the virtual machine Configuration page and Microsoft Defender for Cloud allowed the policy to be enabled and an access request to be made without configuration errors.

8.5 Conclusion

Just-in-time access closes the management port by default and opens it only for an approved address and time window, which is the production answer to the open remote desktop rules used in Labs 2 and 5. The deletion of this policy is also the event that Lab 9 detects, which ties the access control to the monitoring layer.

9. Microsoft Sentinel for SIEM and SOAR

9.1 Objective

The objective was to deploy Microsoft Sentinel on the Lab 6 workspace, connect Azure Activity logs to it, enable a built-in analytics rule, deploy a playbook, and build a detection-and-response chain: a custom rule that detects the removal of the just-in-time policy from myVM and an automation rule that runs the playbook when the alert is created. The chain was then tested by removing the policy.

9.2 Configuration

Table 9.1 lists the components. Azure Activity logs were connected through an Azure Policy assignment at subscription scope with a remediation task, which is the current method for that connector. The playbook was deployed from the lab's changeincidentseverity.json template, and its four API connections were authorised after deployment.

Table 9.1: Components configured in Lab 9

Component	Details
Microsoft Sentinel	Added to the Log Analytics workspace lgawIgnite in AZ500LAB131415
Azure Activity connector	Azure Activity solution installed from the Content hub. Policy assignment Configure Azure Activity logs to stream to specified Log Analytics workspace at subscription scope, parameter lgawIgnite, with a remediation task
Template analytics rule	Suspicious number of resource creation or deployment activities, severity Medium, status Enabled
Playbook	Change-Incident-Severity, a Logic App with one trigger and three actions, deployed to AZ500LAB131415 in East US. The four API connections were authorised by signing in once and pointing all four steps at that connection
Custom analytics rule	Playbook Demo, a scheduled query on AzureActivity for Microsoft.Security/locations/jitNetworkAccessPolicies/delete, run every five minutes. Lookback widened from five minutes to one hour, with suppression
Automation rule	Runs Change-Incident-Severity when an alert from Playbook Demo is created. Sentinel was granted playbook permissions on AZ500LAB131415

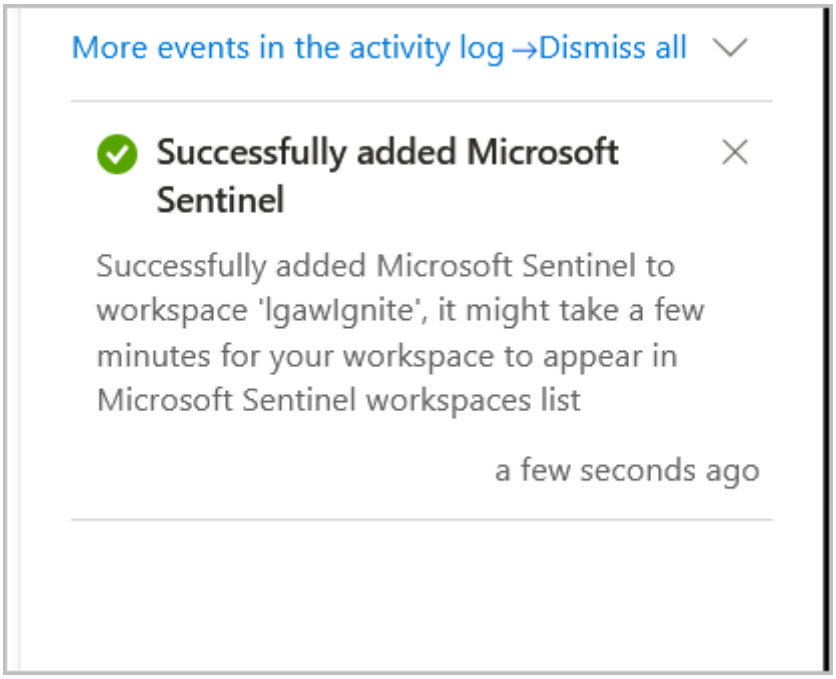


Figure 9.1: Notification that Microsoft Sentinel was added to the workspace lgawIgnite.

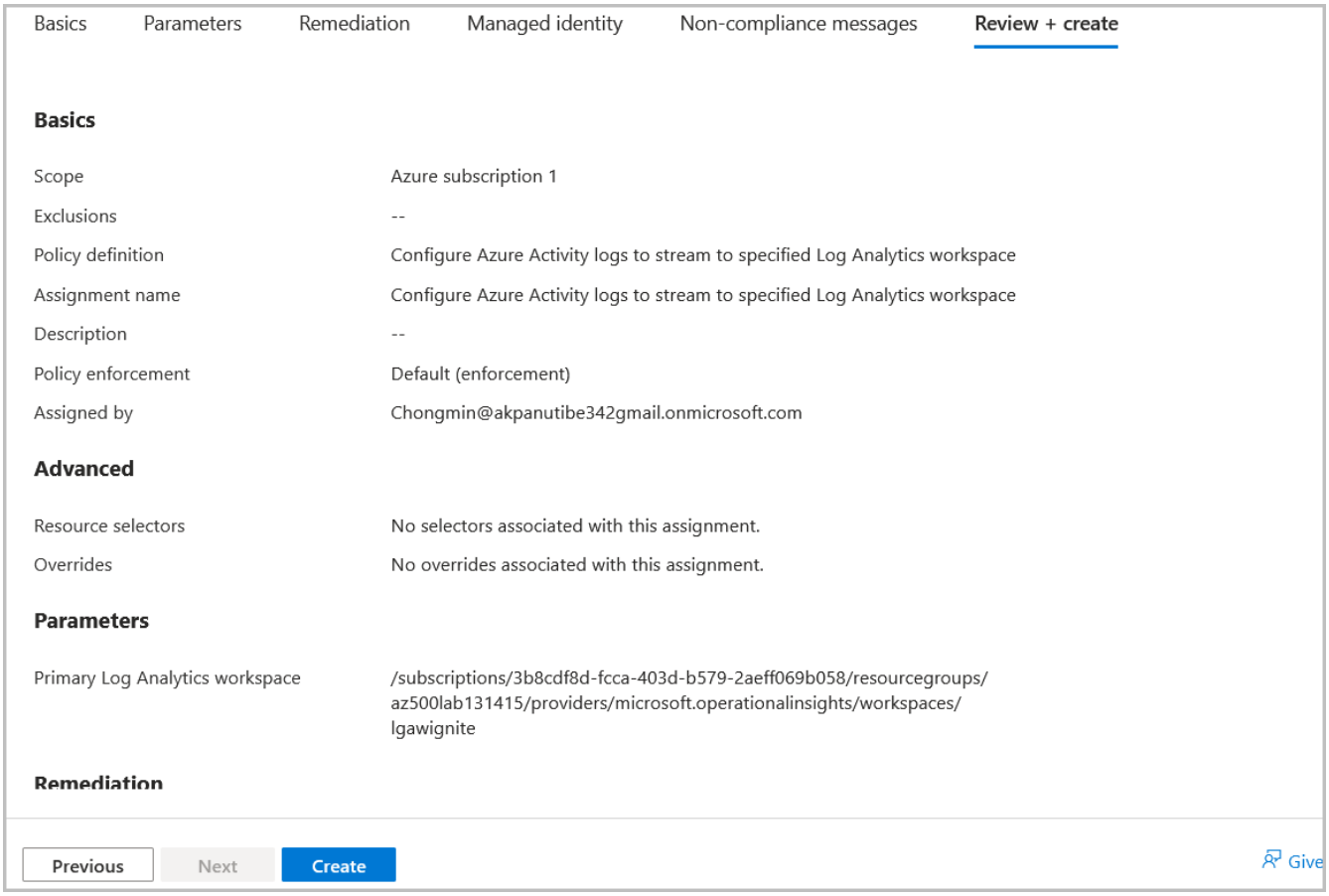


Figure 9.2: Review page of the policy assignment Configure Azure Activity logs to stream to specified Log Analytics workspace, scope Azure subscription 1, parameter lgawIgnite.

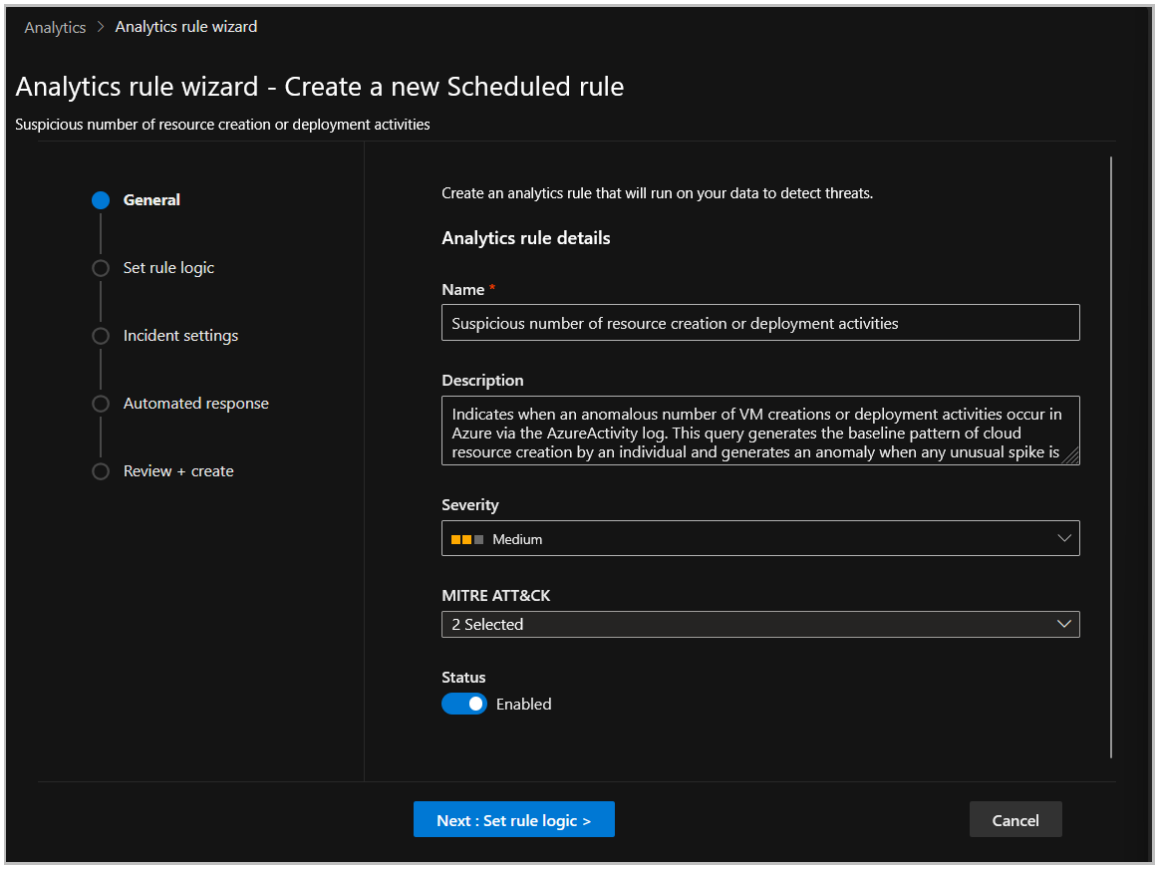


Figure 9.3: Analytics rule wizard for the template rule Suspicious number of resource creation or deployment activities, severity Medium, status Enabled.

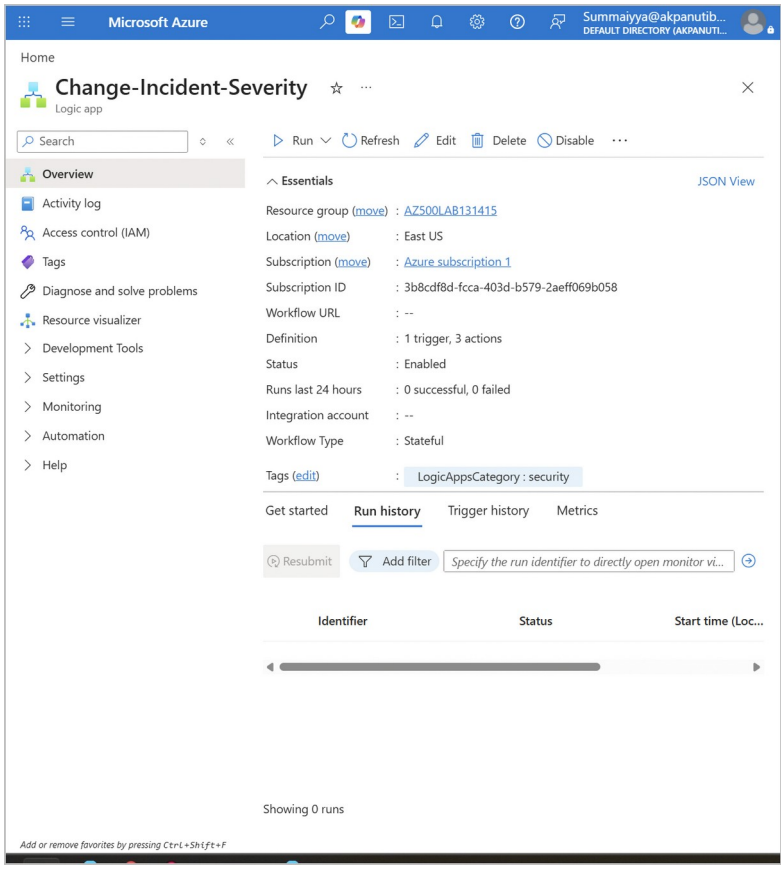


Figure 9.4: Overview of the Logic App Change-Incident-Severity in AZ500LAB131415: one trigger and three actions, status Enabled.

9.3 Tests and results

The chain was tested by removing the just-in-time policy from myVM in Microsoft Defender for Cloud. Table 9.2 lists what followed. The detection worked and the playbook was triggered for every incident, but the playbook runs failed at their incident lookup step, so the severity change was not applied.

Table 9.2: Test sequence and results for Lab 9

Step	Observed result
Remove the JIT policy from myVM	The Configured tab in Defender for Cloud changed from one virtual machine to none (Figure 9.5)
Azure Activity log	Delete JIT Network Access Policies recorded with Started and Succeeded entries, followed by Defender for Cloud updating the network security group
Log ingestion	The event reached the workspace about eight minutes after it happened
Playbook Demo incidents	Four incidents of severity Medium: two per rule run, because the query matched both the Started and the Succeeded entry
Playbook execution	Four runs, matching the incidents, which confirms the automation rule fired
Playbook outcome	Each run failed at Alert - Get incident with NotFound, so the severity change was not made. Resubmitting gave the same result

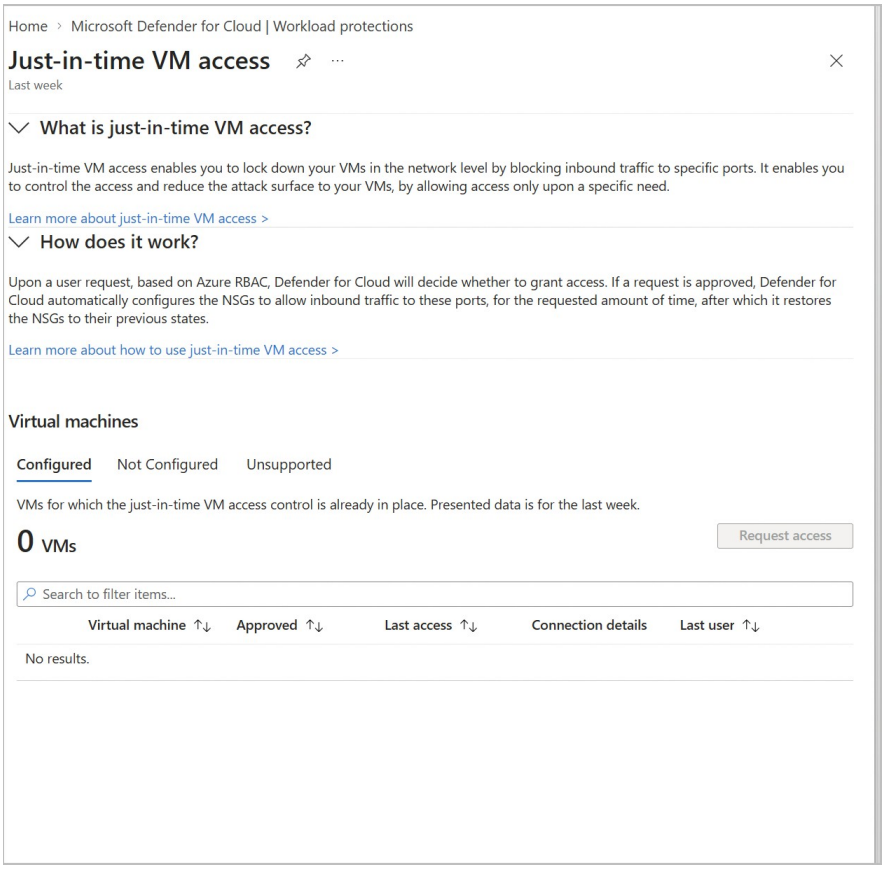


Figure 9.5: Just-in-time VM access after the test. The Configured tab shows no virtual machines, which confirms the policy on myVM was removed and generated the activity log event.

9.4 Issues and resolutions

Three issues were met. The playbook was first greyed out with the message No Microsoft Sentinel permissions; the Manage playbook permissions option was used to grant Sentinel the role it needs on AZ500LAB131415. No incident appeared after the first test because the event arrived in the workspace about eight minutes after it happened, and the rule's five-minute lookback could not see it; the lookback was widened to one hour while

keeping the five-minute frequency, with suppression to avoid repeated alerts. The playbook runs ended as Failed: the trigger succeeded, but the Alert - Get incident step returned NotFound and the remaining steps were skipped. Resubmitting the runs gave the same response, which rules out a one-off timing problem. The NotFound response comes from Sentinel itself, so the connection works and the fault lies in the incident lookup of this playbook template.

9.5 Conclusion

Sentinel detected a real administrative event, raised incidents and invoked the playbook without manual action, which is the detection-and-response chain the lab set out to build. The lab also reproduced two conditions that a security operations team meets in practice: ingestion delay that makes a short lookback miss events, and a playbook that is triggered correctly but fails inside. Both are tuning and testing tasks rather than design faults, and both are recorded in the recommendations. The resource group AZ500LAB131415 was deleted after this lab.

10. Conclusions and recommendations for StashingFintech

Across the nine labs, cloud security depended on layered controls rather than on any single safeguard. Identity, network, storage, container and monitoring controls each blocked a different kind of risk, and the tests showed where one control covered a gap left by another: the storage firewall refused a subnet that the network security group would have let through, and just-in-time access closed a port that the Lab 2 rules left open to the internet.

Most failures in the labs came from configuration errors rather than from technical complexity. A rule saved with the wrong action, a rule with the wrong port, a service manifest with the wrong name and a template with a hard-coded password could each have caused real exposure. The team found them because it tested results rather than trusting settings, and that practice is the first recommendation below.

Identity proved to be as important as the network. Run Command reached a server that the network security group protected, the cluster pulled images through a managed identity rather than a password, and a direct role assignment to a user survived unnoticed until verification. For StashingFintech, Azure role assignments deserve the same review as firewall rules.

Table 10.1 consolidates the recommendations from the nine sections with the finding each one rests on, an owner and a priority. High-priority items should begin before the next sprint.

Table 10.1: Consolidated recommendations

#	Recommendation	Based on	Owner	Priority
1	Require a second person to confirm the action, port, priority and source of every firewall or NSG rule before it is saved, and test every rule from both sides after deployment	Sections 2 and 5	Network lead	High
2	Keep management ports closed by default. Use just-in-time access or Azure Bastion for remote desktop and SSH, and never allow TCP 3389 or 22 from any source in production	Sections 2, 5 and 8	Infrastructure lead	High
3	Grant Azure roles to groups at the narrowest scope and review role assignments monthly for direct grants to individuals	Section 1	Identity team	High
4	Treat Azure role assignments as a control equal to network rules, since Run Command and similar features reach servers without passing the NSG	Sections 1 and 2	Identity team	High
5	Replace storage account keys with Microsoft Entra authentication or shared access signatures, and keep connection scripts that contain keys out of documents and screenshots	Section 5	Engineering lead	High
6	Use managed identities and role assignments for workload-to-service access, as the AKS cluster did for its registry, instead of credentials in configuration	Section 4	Engineering lead	Medium
7	Deploy templates only from trusted or internally hosted sources, and scan them for embedded secrets before use	Section 3	Engineering lead	Medium
8	Review Kubernetes service manifests before deployment, because one annotation decides whether a service is internal or exposed to the internet	Section 4	Engineering lead	Medium

#	Recommendation	Based on	Owner	Priority
9	Measure log ingestion delay for each Sentinel data source and set analytics rule lookback periods above it, with suppression to avoid duplicate incidents	Section 9	SOC	Medium
10	Test every playbook end to end against a real incident before relying on it, and fix the incident lookup in Change-Incident-Severity	Section 9	SOC	Medium
11	Keep Defender for Servers, the data collection rule and the Sentinel workspace running as the monitoring baseline for every virtual machine that handles payment data	Sections 6, 7 and 9	SOC	Low

Confidence in these conclusions is high for the controls that were tested from both sides (Sections 2, 4 and 5) and moderate for the monitoring labs, where the detection worked but the automated response did not complete.

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Appendix A: Evidence index

Every figure in this report is a screenshot taken by the team during the lab sessions. The table lists what each figure shows and the environment it came from. Team A worked in the first subscription and Team B in the second. The original image files have been kept.

Table A.1: Figures and their sources

Figure	What it shows	Source
1.1	az ad user list output with the three lab users	Team A subscription, Cloud Shell, Lab 1
1.2	Dylan Williams added to and listed in the Service Desk group	Team A subscription, Cloud Shell, Lab 1
1.3	Role assignments on AZ500Lab01 before the direct grant was removed	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 1
1.4	Role assignments for Dylan Williams showing the group assignment	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 1
1.5	Diagram of the Lab 1 design	Prepared by the team
2.1	Inbound rules on myNsg (before the port correction)	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 2
2.2	myVmWeb network interface as a member of myAsgWebServers	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 2
2.3	Remote desktop session to myVMMgmt	Team B subscription, RDP client, Lab 2
2.4	IIS welcome page from myVmWeb	Team B subscription, browser, Lab 2
2.5	Remote desktop to myVmWeb refused	Team B subscription, portal and RDP client, Lab 2
3.1	Test-FW01 overview with private IP 10.0.1.4	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 3
3.2	Route FW-DG on Firewall-route	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 3
3.3	Network rule collection Net-Coll01	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 3
3.4	www.bing.com allowed on Srv-Work	Team B subscription, nested RDP session, Lab 3
3.5	www.microsoft.com denied on Srv-Work	Team B subscription, nested RDP session, Lab 3
4.1	Registry repository sample/nginx with tag v1	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 4
4.2	Nodes Ready and registry attached	Team B subscription, Cloud Shell, Lab 4
4.3	nginx welcome page on the public IP	Team B subscription, browser, Lab 4
4.4	Internal IP timing out from a laptop	Team B subscription, browser, Lab 4
4.5	curl to the internal IP from inside a pod	Team B subscription, Cloud Shell, Lab 4
5.1	Storage account network access restricted to the Private subnet	Team B subscription, portal, Lab 5
5.2	Drive Z mapped on myVmPrivate	Team B subscription, RDP session, Lab 5
5.3	Internet test blocked on myVmPrivate	Team B subscription, RDP session, Lab 5
5.4	Share refused and internet allowed on myVmPublic	Team B subscription, RDP session, Lab 5
6.1	Get-AzVM output for myVM	Team A subscription, Cloud Shell, Lab 6

Figure	What it shows	Source
6.2	Log Analytics workspace lgawIgnite	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 6
6.3	DCR1 performance counter data source	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 6
6.4	DCR1 in the data collection rules list	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 6
7.1	Defender plans with Servers On	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 7
8.1	Just-in-time VM access with myVM configured	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 8
8.2	Connect page showing JIT access granted	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 8
9.1	Sentinel added to lgawIgnite	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 9
9.2	Policy assignment for the Azure Activity connector	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 9
9.3	Template analytics rule in the rule wizard	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 9
9.4	Logic App Change-Incident-Severity overview	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 9
9.5	Just-in-time VM access with no configured machines after the test	Team A subscription, portal, Lab 9